Courting Colleagues: Occupational Affinity and Individual Contributions in American Legislative Elections

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October 2026

Abstract

Why do certain professions dominate elected office in the United States? I demonstrate that occupational donor networks provide unequal access to early campaign funds. To do so, I construct an original dataset that classifies 2.7 million donors and nearly 17,000 candidates into shared occupational categories across congressional and state legislative elections (2003-2022). I find that candidates raise an additional 7 percentage points of their individual contributions from donors who share their occupation, relative to competitors in the same race. This advantage is driven by mobilizing more donors, remains strong in the first 90 days, and extends across state and party lines. Yet only high-income professions, such as law, medicine, and business, convert occupational affinity into a net fundraising advantage. Evidence on mechanisms points to network mobilization and professional identity, not policy investment. Together, these dynamics channel early capital toward a narrow set of professions, compounding their advantages in seeking office.

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†I thank Luca Bellodi, Adam Bonica, Brandice Canes-Wrone, Tom Clark, Justin Grimmer, Andrew Myers, Abhinav Ramaswamy, Kasey Rhee, Sofia Valdivia Cox, and Yiqing Xu, as well as participants of the 2025 Stanford-Vienna Workshop on Polarization, the 2025 APSA Annual Meeting, the Canes-Wrone Research Group, and the Stanford Political Economy Graduate Student Workshop for valuable feedback on the project. Andrew Hall, Cassandra Handan-Nader, and Andrew Myers also provided an early version of their state legislative returns dataset, for which I am grateful.

Introduction

Political elites in the United States are drawn disproportionately from a narrow set of high-status professions. White-collar professionals are vastly overrepresented in legislatures, while working-class occupations hold only a small fraction of seats (Carnes 2018). Attorneys, for example, once comprised roughly 80 percent of Congress, a share that has since fallen below 40 percent but still dwarfs their presence in the broader population (Robinson 2017). Scholars have offered several explanations for this imbalance, emphasizing self-selection, the transferability of professional skills, or voter preferences (Miller 1995; Diermeier, Keane, and Merlo 2005; Eulau and Sprague 1964; Hain and Piereson 1975). However, empirical evidence for these accounts remains limited. Why do some professions dominate elected office while others remain almost entirely absent?

A more recent line of work centers on campaign finance. Fundraising plays an outsized role in determining who enters, competes in, and ultimately wins elections (Thomsen 2025). Contributions are especially consequential in primary elections, where partisan cues are absent and candidate quality is difficult to assess. Candidates who raise substantial early funds are more likely to deter challengers and build momentum, as early money signals viability and begets more money (Biersack, Herrnson, and Wilcox 1993; Krasno, Green, and Cowden 1994; Epstein and Zemsky 1995; Magleby, Goodliffe, and Olsen 2018). Yet while we know early money matters, we know far less about its sources and structure: who provides it, why they give, and which candidates benefit most.

This paper explores one potential organizing axis of campaign finance: occupation. If members of a profession mobilize behind candidates from their own ranks, professional networks can supply the early money and resources that establish viability (Bawn et al. 2023). This dynamic may be one source of the occupational imbalance in American legislatures, which, in turn, shapes the policies that governments enact (Carnes 2013). Direct evidence is sparse: Bonica (2020) documents the pattern among attorneys, and to a lesser extent physicians and corporate executives, but it remains unclear whether occupation is a general organizing principle of fundraising or a feature of a small set of elite professions. This paper tests that broader claim directly, examining occupational

fundraising patterns across fourteen professions and industries in U.S. House and state legislative primaries.

To do so, I compile a novel dataset linking biographical information on legislative candidates to individual campaign contributions between 2003 and 2022, classifying more than 2.7 million unique donors and nearly 17,000 candidates into 14 occupations and industries. My main identification strategy compares candidates within the same primary contest using race-occupation fixed effects, holding constant race-level confounders such as district affluence, donor pool composition, and baseline partisanship. The estimates therefore reflect the fundraising advantage a candidate enjoys from co-occupation donors, relative to competitors in the same race. These estimates are conditional on who enters the race: they capture how professional networks advantage candidates already competing, not whether those networks drew them in to begin with.

The results establish occupational affinity as a robust feature of primary elections. Candidates raise an additional 7 percentage points of their individual contributions from co-occupation donors relative to their competitors, an advantage comparable in magnitude to documented donor preferences along racial and gender lines. This advantage stems mainly from more co-occupation donors and, to a lesser extent, from larger contributions. It remains strong in the first ninety days of fundraising, when resources are most critical for viability, and it extends across both state and party lines.

Yet not all professions benefit equally. Only elite occupations, such as attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives, convert affinity into a net fundraising advantage. For most others, including teachers, nurses, and law enforcement officers, co-occupation donors do mobilize, but they are too few or too modestly resourced to outweigh contributions lost from other donor groups. Occupational affinity therefore yields a net fundraising advantage for only a small number of high-income professions, the same professions already overrepresented in American legislatures.

Evidence on mechanisms points to a blend of professional networks and expressive identity rather than policy investment. Among attorneys, co-occupation giving is notably stronger within law-school alumni networks, suggesting that shared professional connec-

tions help channel mobilization. At the same time, occupational affinity remains strong even in unwinnable races, where the eventual nominee has little prospect of holding office and donors can expect no policy return. Adapting the difference-in-differences design of Fouirnaies and Hall (2018), I further show that individual occupation donors are largely unresponsive to whether a candidate gains a profession-relevant committee assignment, even as PACs respond strongly, casting doubt on narrowly instrumental accounts.

This study makes several contributions. Most directly, it establishes occupation as a general organizing principle of campaign finance, extending beyond the well-documented attorney case to a broad range of professions and industries (Bonica 2017, 2020). In doing so, it connects the literature on early money and primary viability (Thomsen 2025; Magleby, Goodliffe, and Olsen 2018) to the persistent puzzle of occupational imbalance in American legislatures (Carnes 2013, 2018). The findings also speak to work on identity-based donor coalitions (Thomsen and Swers 2017; Grumbach and Sahn 2020), highlighting professional identity as another dimension along which political resources are unevenly mobilized. Because a legislator's occupational background shapes the issues she prioritizes, the bills she introduces, and her legislative success (Carnes 2012; Miler 2017; Francis and Bramlett 2017; Makse 2022), this uneven mobilization reaches beyond who governs to whose interests become law.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. I first situate the project within research on donor motivations and occupational representation, then develop a theoretical framework for how occupation structures donor behavior. After introducing the data, classification method, and empirical strategy, I present the main results in two parts. The first establishes occupational affinity as a robust pattern, characterizing when the advantage emerges, how it operates, and which professions convert it into net fundraising gains. The second turns to mechanisms, testing where the network, expressive, and policy-investment channels diverge. I conclude by discussing the implications for candidate selection, political inequality, and the composition of American political elites.

Occupation as an Organizing Force in Campaign Finance

Occupation in Campaign Finance

Scholars generally agree that individual contributions reflect a mix of strategic and expressive motivations (Ensley 2009; McCarty and Poole 1998). Strategic contributions are intended to influence electoral outcomes or secure access and policy benefits (Snyder 1990; Hall and Wayman 1990), while expressive contributions reflect the personal or symbolic value of supporting a candidate or cause (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003). Expressive giving is often rooted in ideological proximity (Bonica 2014; Barber 2016), yet shared policy preferences are not the only basis for expressive attachment. A growing body of work shows that shared identity also structures donor behavior: contributors disproportionately support candidates who share their race, ethnicity, or gender (Grumbach, Sahn, and Staszak 2022; Grumbach and Sahn 2020; Sorensen and Chen 2022; Thomsen and Swers 2017). Occupation is a natural extension of this logic, yet it has drawn far less attention than identities like race and gender.

The most developed line of research on occupation focuses on attorneys. Bonica (2017, 2020) shows that attorney-candidates raise large sums of early money from fellow lawyers, helping them clear early fundraising hurdles and signal viability. This occupational advantage may help explain why attorneys are so heavily overrepresented in elected office: rather than reflecting voter preferences alone, their electoral success appears rooted in occupation-based fundraising dynamics (Carnes and Lupu 2016; Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014; Fong and Grimmer 2016).

Beyond the attorney case, however, evidence is sparse. In related work, Bouton et al. (2024) document that large individual donors are disproportionately male, white, high-income, and concentrated in managerial and highly educated occupations, but do not test whether donors and candidates tend to match on occupation. Stuckatz (2022) demonstrates that the *workplace* can organize individual giving, as employees contribute disproportionately to candidates their employer's PAC supports, but whether occupation

independently structures fundraising remains an open question. The relative lack of attention to profession is notable given the stark occupational imbalance in elected office (Carnes 2018). If part of that imbalance reflects unequal access to early money rather than self-selection or voter preferences alone (Bonica 2017), then whether donors systematically favor candidates from their own profession is directly relevant. Why this advantage might take shape, however, is less obvious.

Three Channels

I consider three complementary channels through which occupation may organize donor behavior: network mobilization, in which professional ties lower the cost of fundraising; expressive identification with one's profession; and policy investment in candidates who share one's occupational interests. These channels are not mutually exclusive, and while the empirics that follow cannot perfectly disentangle them, each implies somewhat distinct empirical patterns that the analysis explores.

Network Mobilization. Professional networks lower the structural cost of fundraising. Candidates typically begin by soliciting close professional contacts, such as colleagues and classmates, who are most likely to respond to an early ask (Feigenbaum and Shelton 2013; Francia et al. 2003; Magleby, Goodliffe, and Olsen 2018). Formal organizations such as bar associations, medical societies, and industry groups reduce transaction costs, facilitate coordination, and raise a candidate's visibility within a pool of potentially sympathetic donors (Bonica 2017). This informational advantage is most valuable early, particularly in primaries, when candidates lack name recognition and media coverage is sparse (Thomsen 2025). Crucially, occupations vary in the density and institutionalization of these networks (Carnes 2018). Professions with established organizations can more easily coordinate contributions, so high-income, well-networked professions are more likely to translate occupational affinity into tangible fundraising advantages, not necessarily because their members care more about politics, but because their networks enable rapid mobilization at the critical early stage.

Expressive Identification. Professions also foster distinct cultures and values, reinforced by shared training, norms, and regulatory experience. These can translate into in-group solidarity, an expressive reason for donors to support one of their own. Attorneys, physicians, and members of other highly professionalized fields may view co-occupation candidates as representing their professional identity and values, much as race or gender structures donor behavior (Grumbach and Sahn 2020; Grumbach, Sahn, and Staszak 2022; Thomsen and Swers 2017). This affinity reflects a desire to see one's group represented in office, independent of any specific policy return, and homophily strengthens these bonds, making appeals from co-professional candidates feel more personally meaningful (McPherson, Smith-Lovin, and Cook 2001).

Policy Investment. Finally, donors may support a candidate from their profession not only to see it represented, but because that representation carries real policy consequences. Professions face common regulatory and legislative concerns: physicians care about health policy, attorneys about legal reform, and real estate developers about land use and taxation (Matter and Stutzer 2015; Bonica, Rosenthal, and Rothman 2019). Donors may believe that a co-occupation candidate will better represent these interests in office, whether through specific policy stances or a general grasp of the profession's priorities. Such concerns are traditionally channeled through formal organizations like the American Bar Association or American Medical Association, but occupational donors can collectively mimic interest-group behavior by supporting candidates from their field. Empirical evidence supports this: corporate executives donate more, and more strategically, when promoted, in keeping with their professional interests (Gordon, Hafer, and Landa 2007; Burris 2005; Fremeth, Richter, and Schaufele 2013; Richter and Werner 2017). More broadly, individual donors favor legislators whose committee assignments match their occupational concerns (Barber, Canes-Wrone, and Thrower 2017), and their contributions often follow the donations of employers and affiliated PACs (Stuckatz 2022). This form of giving need not be narrowly transactional (Powell and Grimmer 2016; Fouirnaies and Hall 2018); it may instead represent a group-based political investment, an effort to elevate the profession's voice within the legislature (Snyder 1990).

These channels often operate together. In the 2014 Republican primary for Georgia's 1st congressional district, pharmacist and State Senator Earl "Buddy" Carter emerged as a frontrunner in part through his professional connections (Bawn et al. 2023). As one observer put it:

> *"You've got Obamacare, all the ... Medicare-Medicaid issues about payment for prescription drugs. You've got all the layers of regulatory paperwork that apply to all businesses, and so you've got a bunch of rich people out there who happen to be pharmacists who want one of theirs up there [in Congress]."* (Bawn et al. 2023, 100)

The remark blends policy stakes with the expressive pull of putting "one of theirs" in Congress, while the mobilization itself is indicative of the network channel: pharmacy owners and employees, along with industry PACs, gave roughly $435,000 to Carter, about 45 percent of his total, a share only a coordinated professional network could deliver.

Early Money and Candidate Viability

Whatever its motive, co-occupation giving may be especially impactful because of *when* it arrives: since professional networks are among the first a candidate calls on, this money tends to come early (Thomsen 2025). Early fundraising is among the strongest predictors of primary survival: candidates who post strong early numbers attract endorsements, deter challengers, and find it easier to raise more, while those who fall short are disproportionately likely to withdraw before election day (Goodliffe 2001; Box-Steffensmeier 1996; Norrander 2000). An occupation that mobilizes behind one of its own can act as an anchoring constituency, supplying the early resources a candidate needs to stay viable in a low-information primary (Bawn et al. 2012, 2023). Early money, in other words, does not just reflect a candidate's strength: it helps create it.

This timing places occupation near the front of a sequential filter. Long before voters weigh in, candidates who assemble early money appear viable, helping them raise more, consolidate support, and stay in the race. By structuring access to that early money, occupation may shape who chooses to run, who survives the primary, and ultimately who reaches office. Professions that differ in their capacity to supply early money may

therefore differ in their ability to move candidates through this filter, which is one reason the occupational composition of legislatures may reflect the structure of professional donor networks rather than voter preferences alone.

Setting and Scope

A final consideration is how partisanship structures giving in primary versus general elections. Individual contributions are heavily influenced by party and ideology (Bonica 2014; Ensley 2009; McCarty and Poole 1998). In general elections, partisan cues give donors a clear basis for evaluating candidates, leaving little room for professional background to operate independently. Primaries strip these cues away. When party labels are uninformative, shared occupation can serve as an alternative heuristic for competence, values, or policy alignment, and professional networks can play a larger role in directing the early contributions that shape viability (Thomsen 2025). Primaries are therefore the natural setting in which to look for occupational affinity, and where the stakes for candidate selection are highest.

Not all professions are equally positioned to draw on these channels. They vary in income, prevalence, and the density and institutionalization of their networks, differences that shape both the strength of occupational affinity and whether it yields a *net* fundraising advantage. I take up this heterogeneity when examining which professions translate affinity into total fundraising gains.

Data

This study draws on original data linking candidate biographies, individual campaign contributions, and election returns across U.S. House and state legislative elections from 2003 to 2022. Candidates and donors are classified into a common set of fourteen occupational categories, allowing direct measurement of occupational alignment between contributors and the candidates they support. I summarize the data and classification process below and provide a more complete discussion in Supplemental Appendix SA-1.

Table 1: List of Occupation and Industry Categories

Occupations	**Industries**
Accountants	Agricultural Production
Attorneys	Construction and Skilled Trades
Corporate Executives	Fossil Fuel
Law Enforcement Officers	Insurance
Nurses	Investments
Physicians	
Professors	
Real Estate Agents/Brokers	
Teachers (Primary/Secondary)	

I draw on several sets of election returns to identify the candidates competing in each primary. For congressional races I use returns from Ansolabehere et al. (2010), extended through 2022 by Myers (2025). For state legislatures, I rely on a newly compiled dataset from Handan-Nader, Myers, and Hall (2026). Candidate occupational backgrounds come primarily from Project Vote Smart, supplemented by Ballotpedia, Makse (2019), Porter, Case, and Treul (2025), and the Martindale-Hubbell Law Directory as merged with DIME by Bonica and Sen (2017).

Individual contribution records come from the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME), which compiles campaign contributions reported to the Federal Election Commission (FEC) and state agencies (Bonica 2024). FEC rules require that contributions above $200 be itemized, and itemized records must include each donor's self-reported occupation and employer. These occupation and employer fields are the basis for matching donors to occupational categories.

Occupation Classification

Candidates and donors are classified into a common set of fourteen categories: nine occupations defined by job title and five industries defined primarily by employer. The industry categories extend coverage to contributors whose job titles do not map to a focal occupation but whose employer places them in a politically salient sector. Table 1 lists the full set of categories.

Because candidate and donor records differ substantially in structure and scale, I clas-

sify each through a distinct pipeline. Both are described in full in Supplemental Appendix SA-1. Project Vote Smart is the primary source for candidates, given its broad coverage of congressional and state legislative races. A large language model (Anthropic's Claude Haiku 4.5) reads each candidate's structured career history (occupation titles and employer names) and returns binary flags for the fourteen categories. I supplement these classifications with the additional sources described above to expand candidate coverage.[1] Validated against hand-coding, the combined procedure achieves 93.6% precision (correctly classifying candidate-category assignments) and 94.7% recall (recovering candidate-category memberships identified by hand) across the fourteen categories. In total, 16,859 primary candidates are classified into at least one of the fourteen categories.

For donors, a hybrid procedure combines deep-learning record linkage (Arora and Dell 2023), large language model verification of borderline matches, and regular-expression matching. Occupation strings are matched to the Bureau of Labor Statistics' Standard Occupational Classification system and employer strings to the Center for Research in Security Prices (CRSP) database of publicly listed firms. On a stratified sample hand-coded against the fourteen focal categories, the procedure achieves 90% precision and 97% recall. Of the donors active in the sample period, roughly 9 million (84%) are classified into at least one occupation and 2.7 million into one of the fourteen focal categories.

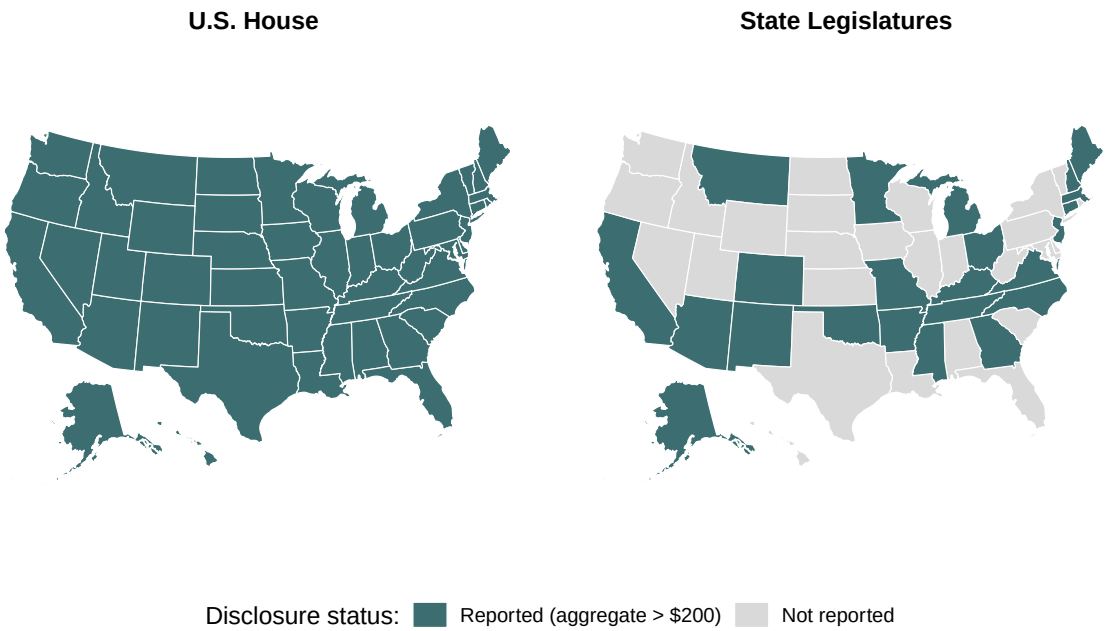
Both pipelines assign affiliations from a subject's entire record, so that a candidate who practiced law before entering business is flagged as both an attorney and a corporate executive, and a donor who reports different occupations across cycles is credited with each. These "ever affiliated" measures are meant to capture the long-term professional identity and network ties most likely to shape giving.

Analysis Sample

The disclosure rules that generate these occupation and employer fields also restrict the sample in two ways. First, data on donor occupation only became available starting in 2003 so the analysis begins with the 2004 cycle. Second, while federal disclosure is uniform,

[1] Supplemental Appendix SA-1 gives the full source hierarchy and override logic.

Figure 1: Donor Occupation Disclosure Requirements for Individuals Contributing More Than $200 to a Candidate: U.S. House vs. State Legislatures



Note: For the U.S. House, the FEC collects donor occupation for contributions to a candidate that sum to over $200. For state legislatures, the states with occupation disclosure requirements consistent with the FEC (or more inclusive), and included in the analysis, are: Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Georgia, Kentucky, Maine, Massachusetts, Michigan, Minnesota, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, North Carolina, Ohio, Oklahoma, Tennessee, and Virginia.

applying to U.S. House races in every state, state-level requirements for state legislative races vary substantially. Some states, such as Oklahoma, require occupation and employer for all contributions, while others impose per-contribution or per-cycle thresholds that differ widely. To maintain consistency with the federal standard, I restrict the state legislative sample to states whose disclosure threshold is at or below the FEC's $200 itemization standard. States with thresholds above $200 are excluded.[2] Figure 1 maps this variation: federal disclosure covers every state (left panel), whereas only twenty-three states meet the threshold for their legislative races (right panel). Non-shaded states are dropped from the state legislative sample.

Of the 79,330 candidate-cycles in the primary election data, 43,168 fall in jurisdictions with FEC-consistent disclosure. I examine occupational coverage in this sample. 31,817

[2]Federal reporting is required once a donor's contributions to a candidate exceed $200. States at or below this standard include those with no threshold (full disclosure), those requiring reporting at lower amounts (e.g., $50–$150), and those requiring it once cycle contributions exceed $200, a more inclusive standard than the FEC's per-candidate threshold.

(73.7%) observations are matched to the candidate-occupation data, with higher coverage among primary and general election winners, U.S. House candidates, and incumbents (Supplemental Table SA-1). Each observation is uniquely defined by a candidate (i), cycle (t), and occupation (j): for example, fundraising from pharmacist donors to Buddy Carter in the 2014 Republican primary for Georgia's first congressional district. Some analyses employ an alternative data structure, "widening" the data to the candidate-cycle level to recover occupation-specific estimates of affinity.

To keep candidates comparable, I limit the estimation sample to contested two-party primaries. For state legislatures, I further restrict to single-member districts and to states whose disclosure rules match the FEC standard (Figure 1), and exclude special elections and nontraditional formats such as top-two and blanket primaries. U.S. House races are not subject to the disclosure restriction, since the FEC enforces reporting uniformly across states. After these restrictions and the exclusion of candidate-cycles with missing occupation data, the estimation sample comprises 11,746 candidate-cycles.[3]

Empirical Strategy: Within-Race Comparisons

Do candidates receive a fundraising advantage from donors with a shared occupational background? To investigate this question, I study candidate fundraising patterns in primary elections for the U.S. House and state legislatures. My main empirical strategy exploits within-race variation in candidate occupations to isolate whether donors are more likely to support candidates who share their profession.

Specification

The core identifying variation comes from comparisons among candidates competing in the same race who differ in whether they share an occupation with a given group of donors. By focusing on within-race comparisons, I hold fixed the electoral environment, donor pool, and other race-specific factors, and ask whether candidates raise systematically more from

[3]Supplemental Table SA-2 reports the sample at each stage of construction.

donors who share their occupation.

I formalize this comparison by estimating the following fixed effects specification:

$$y_{ijt} = \beta \, \text{CandOcc}_{ij} + \mathbf{X}_{it} + \alpha_{r \times j} + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \tag{1}$$

where y_{ijt} is a fundraising outcome for candidate i in cycle t from occupation j, CandOcc_{ij} is an indicator equal to one if candidate i is affiliated with occupation j, $\mathbf{X}_{it}$ is an optional vector of candidate-level controls, and $\alpha_{r \times j}$ represents electoral race-occupation fixed effects. An electoral race is uniquely defined by an office-district-party-cycle pairing.

For example, one race-occupation fixed effect in my sample corresponds to accountant-donors in the Republican primary election for Alaska's at-large congressional district in 2006. Conditional on this fixed effect, the specification asks whether accountant candidates receive greater fundraising support from accountant donors, compared to non-accountant candidates competing in the same election. The coefficient of interest, β, pools across all 14 occupations and industries to capture the average additional fundraising that candidates receive from donors in their own occupation, relative to other candidates in the race.

The generic outcome y_{ijt} stands in for several fundraising measures. The two primary outcomes are $\text{Share}_{ijt}^{cand} = \frac{\text{Amount}_{ijt}}{\text{Amount}_{it}}$, the share of candidate i's cycle t contributions that came from individuals in occupation j, and $\text{Log}(1 + \text{Amount}_{ijt})$, the log of total contributions candidate i receives in cycle t from occupation-j donors. Shares are directly comparable across offices whose fundraising scales differ enormously, from expensive U.S. House races to smaller state-legislative contests, and have a natural interpretation as the fraction of a candidate's contributions attributable to a given occupation. The log-dollar outcome provides a complementary perspective by capturing the level of occupational fundraising rather than its share. Because the outcome is logged, the coefficients are most naturally interpreted as proportional differences.[4] Subsequent sections introduce

[4]Because Amount_{ijt} contains many zeros, the $\text{Log}(1 + \cdot)$ transformation makes this proportional interpretation sensitive to the units in which the outcome is measured (Chen and Roth 2024; Cohn, Liu, and Wardlaw 2022). I therefore report parallel Poisson, intensive-margin, and extensive-margin estimates

additional outcomes.

The race-occupation fixed effects are central to this design. By construction, they absorb all unobserved heterogeneity that varies at the level of the election and occupation: between-race differences in district affluence, donor-pool size, contest salience, and party environment. Because they are indexed by occupation, they also absorb occupation-specific baselines that vary across races, such as attorneys donating more in some districts or the local concentration of an industry shifting its donors' giving.

As a result, β is identified from a highly local comparison: holding fixed the contest environment and donors' baseline propensity to give, do candidates who share an occupation receive more from those donors?

Identification Assumption

Identification relies on the assumption that, within a given race, a candidate's occupational affiliation is uncorrelated with other unobserved determinants of fundraising from occupation-j donors, conditional on the fixed effects and controls. This assumption would be violated if, for example, candidates from a given occupation who enter a particular race systematically differ from their opponents in ways that independently affect their ability to mobilize co-occupation donors, such as personal wealth, prior political experience, or access to pre-existing networks, beyond what is absorbed by the race-occupation fixed effects.

Importantly, candidate entry itself is endogenous. Individuals are more likely to run when they anticipate access to viable fundraising networks, so candidates from a given occupation may selectively enter races with a strong co-occupation donor base, while those who expect little support select out. Any observed fundraising advantage may therefore partly reflect who chooses to run rather than the independent effect of occupation, complicating causal inference.

The results from Equation 1 should therefore be interpreted as the effect of occupational alignment on fundraising, *conditional* on a candidate from a given occupation

in Supplemental Table SA-10, which are substantively similar to the main results.

choosing to enter a race. This conditional estimand reflects how occupational donor networks operate in practice, where strategic entry and fundraising capacity are inherently intertwined.

Robustness

To assess the sensitivity of the results to these remaining concerns, I estimate a series of alternative specifications, reported in Supplemental Table SA-11. First, I supplement the baseline race-occupation fixed effects with candidate fixed effects, which absorb time-invariant candidate characteristics such as experience and baseline fundraising capacity. This specification identifies the coefficient from within-candidate variation across donor occupations within the same race. A positive coefficient reflects a within-candidate increase in fundraising from co-occupation donors relative to donors from other occupations. It alters the estimand, but it addresses the concern that unobserved candidate quality drives the baseline results.

The candidate fixed-effects specification underscores a broader feature of the design: identification in the baseline model comes entirely from within-race comparisons, so only races with candidates of differing occupational backgrounds contribute identifying variation. This restriction reduces the number of contributing races but ensures the estimates capture occupational matching among direct competitors in competitive primaries, where the advantage is likely most consequential.

To assess whether this restriction drives the results, I also replace the combined race-occupation fixed effects with separate district-party-occupation and cycle fixed effects in Supplemental Table SA-11. This specification draws on a broader set of races, including contests that do not contribute identifying variation in the baseline model, at the cost of stronger assumptions about the comparability of candidates across election cycles. The estimates are stable across both specifications, which suggests the results are not an artifact of the particular fixed-effects structure used in the main analysis.

A further concern is generalizability rather than bias. Because the fixed-effects estimator weights each observation by the conditional variance of the occupation-match

indicator, β is an average over an *effective sample* (Aronow and Samii 2016) that need not resemble the nominal one. Here that sample is concentrated: just over a third of candidate-cycles carry 90% of the identifying weight, and the weighted sample tilts toward competitive, crowded, non-incumbent U.S. House primaries and toward attorneys and corporate executives (Supplemental Figure SA-2). The tilt matters only if the co-occupation advantage varies along these dimensions. I find no evidence that it does. The effective and nominal samples are statistically indistinguishable in district income and urbanization, the advantage is flat across terciles of both and of local occupational employment (Supplemental Table SA-14), and it is nearly identical in the House and in state legislatures (Table SA-16). Nor does the result depend on the races or occupations that dominate the weighting: excluding attorneys and corporate executives still yields an advantage of 4.9 percentage points, and dropping the highest-weight races leaves the estimate slightly larger, so the concentration is not inflating it (Supplemental Table SA-15). The pooled estimate is identified from a narrow set of races, but nothing suggests it is specific to them.

A final concern is measurement error in the treatment. Naive use of predicted labels can bias estimates and invalidate standard errors even at high overall accuracy (Egami et al. 2023). The concern is relevant here because classifier quality varies across occupations: elite categories carry more false positives and several non-elite categories more false negatives, both of which attenuate the naive coefficient toward zero.

To correct for this, I apply the design-based supervised learning (DSL) estimator of Egami et al. (2023), which uses a fresh probability sample of 570 hand-coded candidates, with known sampling probabilities, to remove the bias in the predicted treatment. The correction moves every estimate away from zero. The pooled within-candidate affinity coefficient rises from 0.062 to 0.079, and the elite/non-elite gap widens rather than narrowing: 0.125 versus 0.044 under the correction, compared with a naive 0.089 versus 0.039. Because misclassifying a binary treatment attenuates its coefficient, the naive estimates are, if anything, conservative. Occupational affinity, and its concentration among elite professions, is understated by measurement error rather than produced by it. Confidence

intervals under the correction are wider, though the coefficients remain highly significant. Supplemental Table SA-12 reports the full naive-versus-corrected comparison and Supplemental Table SA-13 the per-occupation classifier accuracy.

Occupational Affinity Is a Consistent Feature of Primary Elections

Baseline Occupational Affinity

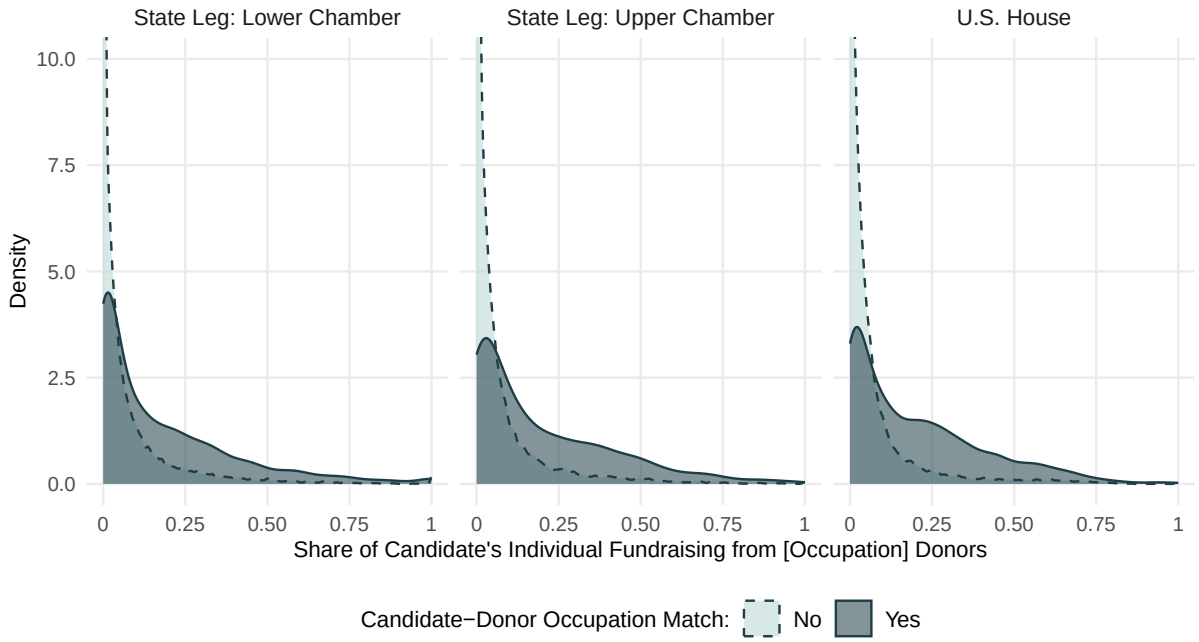
I begin by establishing the baseline existence of occupational affinity in primary elections. Specifically, I examine whether candidates receive a fundraising advantage from donors who share their professional background, relative to otherwise comparable candidates competing in the same election.

To do so, I first compare how much candidates raise from donors in a given occupation when they themselves belong to that occupation versus when they do not. Pooling across candidates, cycles, and occupations provides a simple baseline visualization of occupational affinity: whether, on average, shared professional identity translates into greater financial support from co-occupation donors. I create this comparison with the candidate-cycle-occupation data structure outlined for Equation 1. Subsequent sections estimate this result more formally, before relaxing the pooled approach to examine how these patterns vary across specific professions.

Figure 2 plots the distribution of the share of a candidate's primary election fundraising from individuals that comes from donors in occupation j. Distributions are shown separately for candidates who share that occupation and those who do not, with panels split by office type (U.S. House, upper chamber of a state legislature, and lower chamber of a state legislature).

The figure highlights a clear descriptive difference: candidates who share an occupation with a set of donors receive a substantially larger share of their fundraising from that group. In Figure SA-1 in the Supplemental Appendix, I produce a similar plot, but filter

Figure 2: Candidates Raise a Greater Share of Contributions from Their Own Occupation



Note: Candidate-Donor Occupation Match indicates whether a candidate shares a background in occupation j with a set of donors. The outcome is the amount of money a candidate raised from occupation j, divided by the total amount they received from individual donors.

out all observations where a candidate raised zero dollars from an occupation. The pattern is highly similar, demonstrating that the results are also not a product of data sparsity. The marked stability of the pattern across office types provides a strong justification for the pooled specification that follows.

I now turn to the pooled specification from Equation 1 to more rigorously estimate the occupational fundraising advantage across all occupations. Table 2 reports estimates using two outcomes: a candidate's share of total individual contributions that come from occupation-j donors (columns 1–3) and the logged amount of money raised from occupation-j donors (columns 4–6). Because the within-candidate share outcome is defined only for candidate-cycle observations with nonzero total individual fundraising (a nonzero denominator), observations that do not meet this criterion are excluded. This restriction modestly reduces the sample size and accounts for the small difference in the number of observations across models.

Columns 1 and 4 present a simple benchmark that omits both fixed effects and controls. In this raw comparison, candidates raise substantially more from donors in their

Table 2: Fundraising Advantage from Same-Occupation Donors

	Within-Candidate Share			Log(1 + OCC Funds)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Candidate-Donor	0.13	0.07	0.07	2.48	1.24	1.04
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.04)	(0.09)	(0.09)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746
Controls			✓			✓
Race-OCC FE		✓	✓		✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. Log(1+OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors. Supplemental Table SA-3 reports all coefficients.

own profession, compared to other candidates. Candidate-donor occupation match is associated with a 13 percentage-point higher within-candidate share (column 1) and 2.48 log points more in occupation-j contributions (column 4).

Columns 2 and 5 introduce race-occupation fixed effects, comparing fundraising from a given occupation among candidates *within* the same contest. After accounting for differences across office, geography, party, and occupation, the estimated advantage attenuates but remains sizable: candidates raise 7 percentage points more of their funds from co-occupation donors (column 2) and 1.24 log points more in logged dollars (column 5), corresponding to approximately 246% more occupation-j money relative to non-co-occupation candidates in the same race.

Columns 3 and 6 add incumbency controls, yielding my preferred specification.[5] The estimates are nearly unchanged: 7 percentage points for within-candidate share (column 3) and 1.04 log points for logged dollars (column 6), indicating that incumbency status does not account for the within-race occupational fundraising advantage. Taken together, these results demonstrate that a substantial occupational fundraising advantage persists

[5]Supplemental Table SA-3 reproduces this specification with the incumbency control coefficients printed.

even under demanding within-contest comparisons.

While Table 2 pools U.S. House and state legislative candidates, the results are not driven by one office alone. Table SA-16 in the Supplemental Appendix presents estimates disaggregated by office. Occupational alignment confers a highly consistent fundraising advantage across both settings: the within-candidate share coefficient is 7 percentage points for both House and state legislative candidates, while the corresponding occupation-j log-dollar estimates are 1.06 and 0.94, respectively. To aid interpretation, the table also reports the mean outcome, Mean(y_{it}), which varies substantially across offices. Differences across chambers thus arise primarily from baseline fundraising levels rather than from variation in the strength of occupational affinity.

Because the amount outcome is log-transformed, the reported means are averages of log(1+Amount), which in a skewed distribution fall below the log of the raw mean. In raw dollars, average primary fundraising from a given occupation is approximately $37,650 for U.S. House candidates and $2,020 for state legislative candidates, compared to average total individual primary fundraising of $427,447 and $29,141.

Occupational Fundraising in Context

How large are these occupational fundraising advantages in substantive terms? Are they large enough for any individual occupation to be meaningful in an electoral context? One way to answer this is by benchmarking against other well-documented forms of identity-based affinity.

To do so, I turn towards a candidate-cycle specification, which allows me to compute separate estimates for individual groups. I fit the following specification:

$$y_{it} = \beta \, \text{CandOcc}_i + \mathbf{X}_{it} + \delta_r + \epsilon_{it}, \tag{2}$$

where y_{it} is a fundraising outcome for candidate i in cycle t from the focal occupation, CandOcc_i is an indicator equal to one if candidate i is affiliated with the focal occupation, $\mathbf{X}_{it}$ is an optional vector of candidate-level controls, and δ_r represents race (office-district-party-cycle) fixed effects.

Affinity Beyond Occupation Replacing the candidate occupation indicator in Equation 2 with an indicator for female candidates, I estimate gender-based fundraising affinity on the same sample of contested primaries. Female candidates raise an additional 9 percentage points (SE = 0.00) of their total individual fundraising from female donors relative to male candidates competing in the same race, only slightly larger than the 7-percentage-point occupation-based affinity estimate in Table 2. On the log scale, however, the pattern reverses: the gender estimate is 0.61 log points (0.05), compared to 1.04 log points for occupation (Supplemental Table SA-17 reports the full results for gender). These gender affinity estimates closely mirror those reported by Thomsen and Swers (2017), indicating that my results replicate an established pattern. Occupational ties therefore generate a fundraising response on the same scale as one of the most salient identities in American politics.

A similar comparison can be drawn with race-based donor affinity. Grumbach and Sahn (2020) find that, in U.S. House general elections, the nomination of an Asian American or Latino candidate increases the district's share of contributions from co-ethnic donors by roughly 10 percentage points, while Black nominees increase the share of Black contributions by about 3 percentage points. By comparison, the estimates in Table SA-16 indicate that occupational alignment in the U.S. House produces a 7 percentage point increase in the share of primary election funds from co-occupation donors, a pattern that is somewhat smaller than the largest co-ethnic affinities but larger than the Black donor response. Occupational affinity is thus comparable in magnitude to other identity-based affinities documented in campaign finance.

The Magnitude of Occupational Affinity To provide a clearer sense of the substantive magnitude of occupational affinity, I return to Equation 2 and estimate it separately for each of the fourteen occupations and industries in both U.S. House and state legislative contests. I fit each model using Poisson regression with raw dollar contributions as the outcome. Estimating in levels keeps fundraising on its natural scale and sidesteps the log-transformation and back-transformation that the highly skewed, zero-inflated distribution of contributions would otherwise require, steps that can complicate interpretation

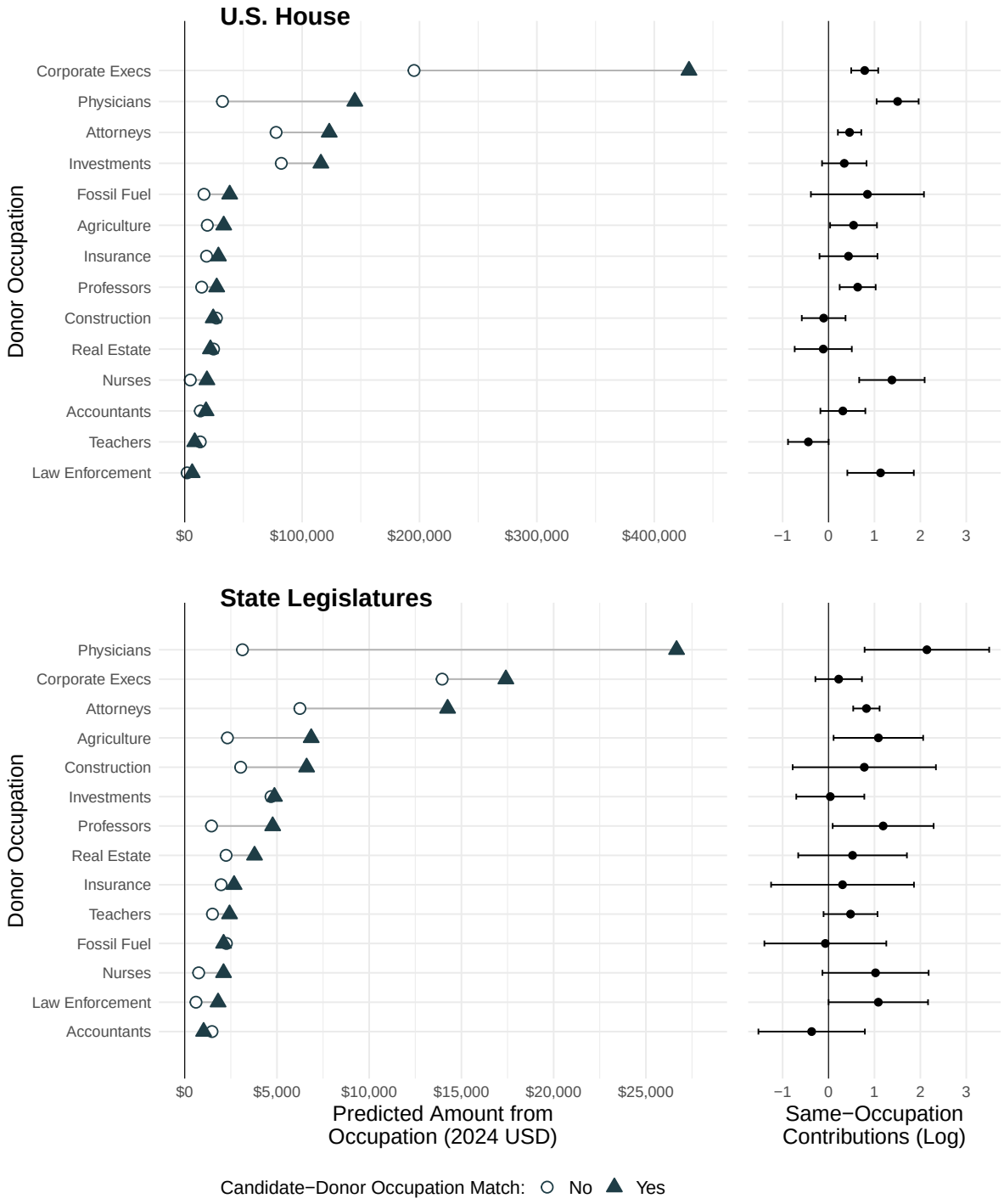
and potentially bias predictions (Chen and Roth 2024; Manning 1998; Cohn, Liu, and Wardlaw 2022; Silva and Tenreyro 2006).

For each candidate-cycle observation I then generate two predicted fundraising totals from the fitted model: one that assigns the candidate to the focal occupation and one that does not. Averaging the difference between these predictions across candidates yields the average change in fundraising associated with occupational membership. Because the fixed effects enter the prediction step directly, these estimates capture within-race contrasts rather than unconditional differences in mean fundraising. The result is a descriptive benchmark for the average dollar advantage that occupational membership confers, estimated separately for each of the fourteen groups.

Figure 3 summarizes these estimates in two stacked panels (U.S. House on top, state legislatures below). The left sub-panel reports predicted contributions in 2024 dollars. Filled triangles mark candidates who share the donor occupation and hollow circles those who do not, so the gap between them is the dollar advantage of occupational membership. The right sub-panel plots the corresponding Poisson coefficient on candidate-donor occupation match. Because the model is Poisson, the coefficient has a multiplicative interpretation: $\exp(\beta) - 1$ gives the proportional premium for a co-occupation candidate, and points right of zero indicate a same-occupation advantage. Presenting the two scales together separates two ways an occupation's affinity can be "large": a group may loom large in total dollars yet show only a modest proportional premium, or give little in absolute terms while still posting a sizable, precisely estimated co-occupation effect.

Across the two sub-panels, how much an occupation gives overall and how strongly it favors its own are nearly unrelated. Corporate executives, attorneys, and physicians are among the largest contributors in either chamber, in line with prior work (Stuckatz 2022; Bonica, Rosenthal, and Rothman 2019; Bonica 2020), and each directs disproportionate support toward its own: physicians most dramatically (a co-occupation match raises predicted giving roughly fourfold in the House and eightfold in state legislatures), attorneys most consistently across chambers, and corporate executives strongly in the House but with no detectable affinity in the states. Other large contributors show no

Figure 3: Average Predicted Fundraising by Candidate and Donor Occupation



Note: Average predicted values from Equation 2. Each row corresponds to a donor occupation. In the left sub-panel, the x-axis reports contributions in 2024 USD: filled triangles mark candidates who share the occupation, hollow circles mark non-aligned candidates, and the distance between them is the dollar advantage of occupational membership. The right sub-panel plots the corresponding Poisson coefficient on candidate-donor occupation match, with 95% confidence intervals and a reference line at zero. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Since $\exp(\beta) - 1$ is the proportional change in expected contributions, points to the right of zero indicate a same-occupation advantage. Agriculture, Construction, Fossil Fuel, Insurance, and Investments are industry aggregates, the remaining categories are individual occupations. Table 1 gives the full category definitions. The full results are presented in Supplemental Tables SA-18 and SA-19.

such loyalty: investors rank among the largest House donors yet post a co-occupation advantage indistinguishable from zero (Carpenter et al. 2022; Ban and You 2019). Accountants, real estate agents, insurance, construction, and fossil fuel similarly show little reliable co-occupation affinity.

The reverse case is more telling. Several occupations that barely register in absolute dollars post some of the largest proportional affinity in the sample: in the U.S. House, a co-occupation match more than triples predicted giving for both nurses and law enforcement officers, while professors and agriculture post significant premiums in both chambers. The sums are small, but the proportional pull toward fellow professionals ranks among the strongest in the data. A few occupations instead sort their loyalty by office. Teacher affinity is negative in the House but positive, though imprecisely estimated, in state legislatures, consistent with the greater salience of statehouses for education policy.

Having established the baseline pattern across both outcomes and illustrated its absolute scale, I focus the remaining analyses on the within-candidate share measure, for the comparability and interpretability noted above. Parallel specifications using log-dollar outcomes are reported in Supplemental Tables SA-22 and SA-20. The results are substantively similar throughout.

Contextual Variation

Does occupational affinity vary across electoral contexts? In this section, I explore this question across three dimensions: open-seat primaries, safe districts, and crowded primaries. Column 1 of Table 3 reproduces the baseline estimate from Equation 1. Columns 2–4 then re-estimate the specification on subsets of the data: open-seat races (column 2), districts that are safe for the candidate's party, defined as those where the co-partisan presidential nominee received more than 60% of the two-party vote share (column 3), and crowded primaries with three or more candidates (column 4).

Occupational affinity proves stable across electoral contexts, varying only modestly from one setting to the next. Against a baseline advantage of 7 percentage points, the estimate is slightly larger in open-seat primaries (8 points, column 2), somewhat smaller

Table 3: Fundraising Advantages from Same-Occupation Donors, Across Contexts

	Within-Candidate Share			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.08	0.05	0.07
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Sample	Pooled	Open Seat	Safe	Crowded
Observations	155,271	57,340	61,121	68,098
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	4,441	4,583	5,152
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. A parallel table with log-dollar outcomes is reported in Supplemental Table SA-20. Supplemental Table SA-5 reports all coefficients.

in safe districts (5 points, column 3), and essentially unchanged in crowded primaries (7 points, column 4). The open-seat coefficient is only slightly larger than the baseline, but its setting is consequential. Open seats are the principal entry point to a legislature: with no incumbent in the race, they are where a body's occupational composition is most directly set, and where early money might have the greatest impact on who emerges as viable (Thomsen 2025). Affinity is, if anything, strongest precisely here.

The open-seat advantage matters because it compounds. A candidate who converts co-occupation support into an open-seat victory enters future elections as an incumbent, after which the well-documented advantages of incumbency make fundraising and reelection far easier (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014; Jacobson 2015). An edge at entry can thus persist across a career, linking these patterns to the occupational imbalance that motivates the paper (Carnes 2018). Notably, affinity is no stronger in safe districts, where the primary effectively decides the seat, than in the average race, a pattern inconsistent with donors concentrating support where officeholding is most assured. I return to this theme below.

Characterizing the Advantage

I now characterize occupational affinity along three dimensions: *when* it emerges in the campaign cycle, *how* it operates at the level of individual donors, and *who* the occupation donors are.

Early Money Prior work suggests that *early* contributions may be especially consequential for downstream candidate performance (Thomsen 2025; Bonica 2017). If occupational affinity is concentrated in the earliest stages of fundraising, when resources are most critical for establishing viability, it would underscore the practical importance of co-occupation support for candidates seeking to compete.

Following the definition of early fundraising proposed by Case and Porter (2025), I employ a candidate-centered measure: the first 90 days after a candidate receives her *first* contribution from an individual donor. Candidate self-loans are excluded, ensuring the measure captures the initial fundraising window when outside individuals begin supporting the campaign. I again estimate the pooled model from Equation 1, but now define the outcome as the share of early individual-donor dollars that originate from donors in the candidate's own occupation.

The resulting estimate, reported in column 1 of Table 4, indicates that occupational affinity is indeed pronounced in early fundraising. When a candidate shares an occupation with a set of donors, contributions from those donors comprise an additional 7 percentage points of the early money the candidate receives. Because this support is present from the outset, before endorsements, polling, or coverage establish viability, it suggests it is not merely a bandwagon effect that tracks viability but a force that helps shape the field.

More Donors, Slightly Larger Checks I now turn to the composition of the occupational fundraising advantage: increased fundraising could arise through more donors, larger contributions from the same donors, or some combination of the two.

Column 2 of Table 4 presents coefficient estimates from the specification in Equation 1, where the outcome is the share of a candidate's total individual donors drawn from a given occupation, ranging from 0 (no donors from the occupation) to 1 (complete reliance

Table 4: Dimensions of the Occupational Fundraising Advantage

	When	How		Who	
	Early $	Donors	Log(Avg. Gift)	Out-State $	Out-Party $
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.06	0.12	0.05	0.10
Occupation Match	(0.01)	(0.00)	(0.03)	(0.00)	(0.01)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	153,065	155,271	101,822	124,910	87,626
Candidate-Cycles	11,576	11,746	11,303	9,418	6,633
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Columns (1), (2), (4), (5) are within-candidate shares: occupation-j $ (or donors) divided by the candidate's total in the corresponding pool. Column (3) *Log(Avg. Gift)* is the natural log of the average contribution from occupation-j donors to a candidate. Sample sizes in columns (3)–(5) are smaller because these outcomes require a nonzero denominator or at least one occupation-specific contribution. A parallel table with log-dollar outcomes is reported in Supplemental Table SA-22. Supplemental Table SA-4 reports all coefficients.

on it). The coefficient in column 2 of Table 4 indicates a 6 percentage point increase in the share of a candidate's donors that come from a shared occupation, relative to competitors in the same race who do not share that occupation. Co-occupation donors make up a notably larger share of aligned candidates' contributor base.

I next ask whether these donors also contribute *larger* amounts to their fellow professionals. To assess this, I again estimate Equation 1, now defining the outcome as the average contribution amount per occupation-specific donor. This outcome is measured as the total amount contributed by donors in a given occupation, divided by the number of distinct donors from that occupation. Although this variable is constructed as an average for each candidate-cycle-occupation observation, it remains right-skewed, so I take its natural log prior to estimation.

Because the outcome is measured in log dollars, the coefficient in column 3 of Table 4 implies that candidates receive, on average, contributions from co-occupation donors that are approximately 0.12 log points (about 13%) larger than those received by competitors who do not share the occupation. This result is substantively modest. In raw dollars, the

average contribution amount from occupation donors in the sample is $804 ($1,208 for U.S. House candidates and $543 for state legislative candidates).

The results from columns 2 and 3 of Table 4 suggest that the occupational fundraising advantage arises primarily through a broader donor base. Candidates who share an occupation attract meaningfully more donors from that profession, and while they also receive modestly larger individual contributions, the gift-size channel appears secondary.

This distinction matters beyond accounting. A broad base of co-occupation donors signals breadth of support and, because individual donors face per-election contribution limits, supplies more distinct contributors to draw on as the race continues. Such breadth is more consistent with mobilization through broad professional networks than with a few committed patrons.

Crossing State and Party Lines I now consider whether occupational affinity extends across two important boundaries: state and party lines.

The rise of a national donorate is an important development in modern campaign finance. The median House incumbent raises a growing share from out-of-district donors (Gimpel, Lee, and Pearson-Merkowitz 2008), and members appear responsive to this national base in ways that shape representation (Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022). One open question is whether occupational ties help candidates reach these distant donors. Professional networks are often national in scope, sustained by associations, conferences, and institutional ties that cut across state lines, so co-occupation donors may reach far beyond a candidate's home state.

For this test, the outcome is the share of a candidate's out-of-state individual contributions that come from occupation-specific donors (Equation 1). Candidates receive an additional 5 percentage points of their out-of-state money from co-occupation donors (column 4 of Table 4), relative to competitors who do not share the focal occupation. Occupational affinity, then, is not confined to a candidate's home state: it reaches into national professional communities, allowing a professional network to partly substitute for a strong local donor base and tying officeholders to a constituency whose preferences need not track their district's (Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022).

I next ask whether occupational affinity extends across party lines. This is a demanding test, as decades of research underscore the durability of partisanship and ideology in structuring political behavior (Ansolabehere, de Figueiredo, and Snyder 2003; Barber 2016; Barber, Canes-Wrone, and Thrower 2017), especially in the polarized period the sample covers (2003–2022). If professional identity can nonetheless elicit cross-party giving, occupation operates on a dimension at least partly orthogonal to ideology.

I again rely on Equation 1, with the outcome defined as the share of a candidate's out-party individual contributions that come from occupation-specific donors. Among the contributions that do cross party lines, this measures how far professional identity organizes giving. Are occupation donors especially likely to set aside party loyalty and support one of their own? To identify donor partisanship, I examine each donor's full contribution history and retain only those who have donated to four or more unique candidates. Among these, I classify as strong partisans those who directed 75% or more of their contributions to candidates of a single party. A donation is then coded as out-party when it flows from a strong partisan of one party to a candidate of the other.[6] The results, presented in column 5 of Table 4, reveal a notable pattern of cross-party giving among co-occupation donors. The estimated coefficient of 0.10 indicates that candidates receive a 10 percentage point larger share of their out-party money from donors who share their occupation, relative to competitors who do not.

To put this in perspective, House candidates raise an average of $10,553 in total out-party money (2024 USD). A 10 percentage point shift in the share from co-occupation donors corresponds to roughly $1,055 in additional cross-party support.[7] While modest in absolute terms, this is notable in a period when cross-party donations are otherwise rare, and it suggests professional identity operates at least partly independent of partisan attachment. This average also masks considerable variation: in some races and professions, cross-party occupational giving runs considerably higher.

[6]Supplemental Table SA-21 presents results from a more stringent classification, in which strong partisans are donors who directed 80% or more (rather than 75%) of their contributions to candidates of one party, as well as from a log-dollar specification of out-party giving in place of the within-candidate share. The results are highly similar.

[7]Supplemental Table SA-22 reports the corresponding result in log dollars, which is similar.

Taken together, these patterns suggest that occupational affinity remains robust in the earliest stages of fundraising, operates primarily through broad donor mobilization rather than through larger contributions, and is not restricted to a fixed set of local, co-partisan donors. The next section explores how occupational affinity relates to candidates' total fundraising performance.

Occupational Affinity and Total Fundraising

The occupational affinity documented so far captures only one component of a fundraising advantage: contributions from donors within the same occupation. Whether it translates into a *net* gain depends on giving from other occupations. If co-occupation support is offset by fewer outside contributions, affinity may reflect substitution rather than an overall advantage.

Whether these patterns help explain the occupational imbalance of American legislatures (Carnes 2018) therefore depends on two questions the pooled specification cannot answer: which professions translate occupational affinity into net fundraising advantages, and what share of those advantages comes from co-occupation giving?

To address these questions, I group the fourteen occupation and industry categories into two sets: *elite occupations* (attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives) and the remaining eleven categories. These three elite categories correspond to the occupations and industries whose members are, on average, among the highest-income donors in the sample, and whose professional donor networks are among the most extensively documented in the campaign finance literature (Gordon, Hafer, and Landa 2007; Bonica 2020; Richter and Werner 2017).[8] I then estimate a variant of Equation 1 in which the candidate-donor occupation match indicator is interacted with occupation group $g \in G = \{\text{elite}, \text{other}\}$:

[8]The decision to pool these three categories does not drive the results. Appendix Figure SA-4 re-estimates the decomposition separately for each elite occupation; the co-occupation advantage remains positive and significant for all three, confirming the pattern is common to the group rather than driven by any single profession.

$$y_{ijt} = \sum_{g \in G} \beta_g \left(\text{CandOcc}_{ij} \times \mathbf{1}\{\text{OccGroup}_j = g\} \right) + \mathbf{X}_{it} + \alpha_{r \times j} + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \tag{3}$$

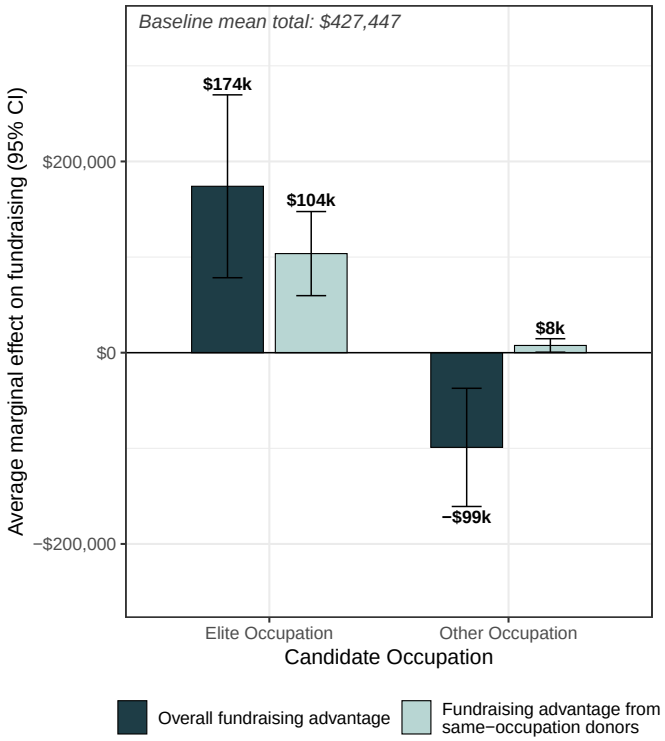
The coefficients β_g in Equation 3 measure the occupational fundraising advantage separately for each occupation group. All other terms are as defined in Equation 1. As before, I estimate the model by Poisson in levels (contributions in 2024 USD), which keeps fundraising on its natural scale and avoids the log-transformation bias discussed earlier, fitting it separately by chamber for two outcomes: total individual contributions and same-occupation contributions. For each, I compute average marginal effects by toggling the match indicator within each occupation group. Because the fixed effects are incorporated into prediction, the AMEs reflect within-race contrasts rather than unconditional differences in fundraising. This decomposition separates the portion of the advantage attributable to the co-occupation channel from the total, inclusive of any spillover to or displacement from other donor groups.

Figure 4 presents the results for candidates in U.S. House primaries. Candidates from elite occupations enjoy large total fundraising advantages: approximately $174,000 more in individual contributions per race, against a baseline mean of roughly $427,000. A substantial share of this advantage runs through the co-occupation channel. Same-occupation contributions account for approximately $104,000 of the $174,000 total, nearly 60%. The remainder reflects higher contributions from donors *outside* the candidate's occupation, consistent with a dynamic in which strong early co-occupation support signals viability to the broader donor pool.

The pattern for other occupations differs dramatically. Despite positive co-occupation fundraising (approximately $8,000), candidates from these professions face a net fundraising *disadvantage* relative to otherwise comparable candidates in the same race, raising roughly $99,000 less in total individual contributions. The co-occupation channel operates for these professions, but the scale of same-occupation giving is more than offset by lower contributions from donors in other occupations.

State legislative contests show a broadly similar pattern, albeit noisier and at a smaller scale (Supplemental Figure SA-5). Elite-occupation candidates raise approxi-

Figure 4: Fundraising Advantage of Elite Occupations Comprised Largely of Co-Occupation Donations in U.S. House Primaries



Note: Average marginal effects from Poisson regressions of individual contributions (2024 USD) on candidate-donor occupation match interacted with occupation group (elite vs. other), with incumbency controls and race-occupation fixed effects. Two outcomes per group: total individual contributions and same-occupation contributions. Elite occupations: attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives. Other occupations: remaining eleven occupations. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Supplemental Table SA-6 reports the underlying regression coefficients.

mately $4,000 more in total individual contributions against a baseline mean of roughly $29,000. The co-occupation channel again accounts for a large share of candidates' potential fundraising advantage: the same-occupation advantage for these candidates is approximately $6,000, and is statistically significant. The co-occupation advantage exceeds the total advantage, implying that the increase in same-occupation donations is partially offset by a decrease in contributions from other donors. The chief difference from the House results is precision: the total fundraising advantage is imprecisely measured, and for other occupations the total and co-occupation estimates are small and statistically insignificant.

The decomposition clarifies why occupational affinity, although present across virtu-

ally all professions, translates into a net fundraising advantage for only a few. The binding constraint is not whether a profession's donors activate on behalf of co-occupation candidates (they generally do), but whether the profession's donor pool is large enough and wealthy enough to convert that activation into a net fundraising advantage. Elite professions satisfy this condition; others do not. Relative to their share of the workforce, attorneys and corporate executives are each over-represented in individual-donor *dollars* by more than twentyfold, both because a larger share of their members give and because those who give write substantially larger checks. Together the two occupations supply more than half (54%) of the individual dollars raised by candidates in the sample (Supplemental Figure SA-3). Teachers, nurses, and law-enforcement officers, by contrast, are at or below their workforce share in both donors and dollars, so even strong co-occupation mobilization operates on a far smaller base. To the extent that early money determines who can viably compete in a primary (Thomsen 2025), these dollar-level asymmetries help explain why certain professions remain overrepresented in elected office and others remain largely absent.

Even where affinity produces no net gain, it may still shape candidates' ties to their professional communities. A teacher-candidate who raises much of her money from fellow teachers may feel heightened accountability to that base (Carnes 2013, 2018). In this sense, occupational affinity can influence representation even when it does not shape electoral outcomes.

What Drives Occupational Affinity?

The preceding results establish occupational affinity as a robust feature of primary elections. But what *drives* it? The theoretical framework developed above identifies three complementary channels. *Policy investment* accounts predict that donors support co-occupation candidates to secure favorable policy outcomes, implying that affinity should be strongest where the expected return is highest: in winnable districts and for candidates who gain access to profession-relevant committees. *Network mobilization* accounts predict that interpersonal and institutional ties channel contributions to co-occupation

candidates, implying that affinity should be amplified within denser professional networks. *Expressive identity* accounts predict that donors give to candidates "like them" for reasons of professional solidarity, implying that affinity should persist even where strategic returns are negligible.

These channels likely operate at least partially in tandem, so the goal is to weigh their relative strength rather than isolate a single mechanism. To probe the instrumental channel, I test whether affinity attenuates where the expected policy return is low and whether co-occupation donors respond when a candidate gains a profession-relevant committee seat, adapting the difference-in-differences design of Fouirnaies and Hall (2018). To probe the network channel, I ask whether co-occupation giving is amplified within shared law-school alumni networks, where professional ties are densest.

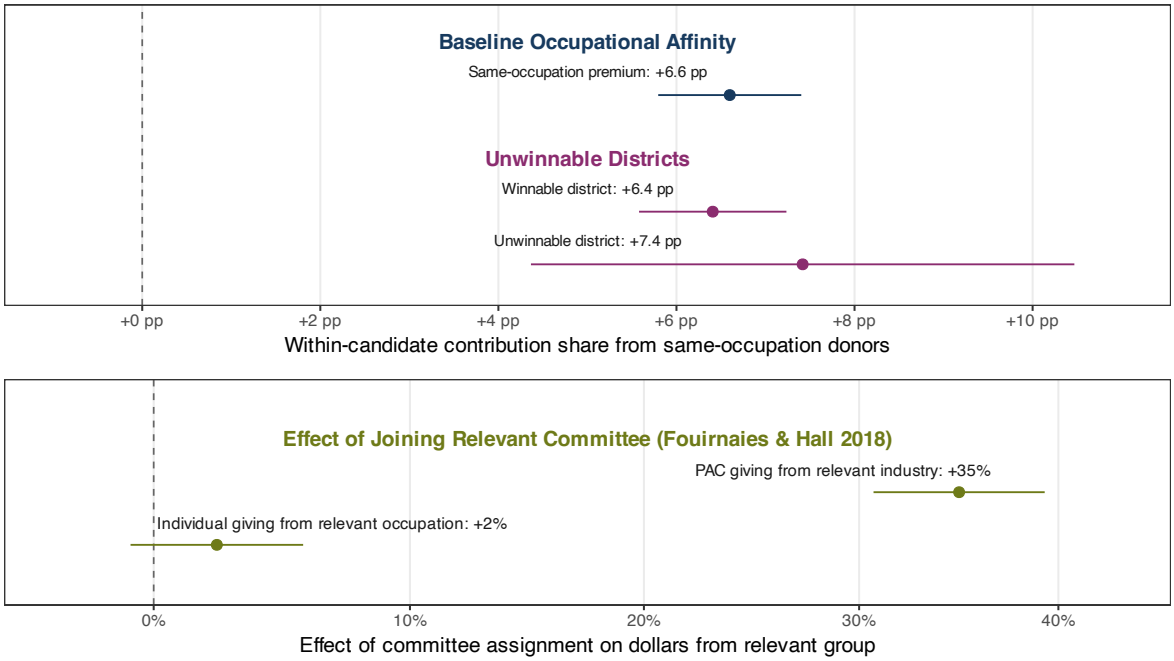
Limited Evidence of Policy Investment

If occupational affinity reflects policy investment, two patterns should appear. First, affinity should attenuate when the candidate is unlikely to hold office, since the expected policy return approaches zero. Second, occupational donors should increase support for any legislator who gains a profession-relevant committee seat, regardless of that legislator's own occupation, since committee membership enhances the capacity to deliver targeted benefits.

Unwinnable Districts To test the first prediction, I split the sample by district safety and re-estimate the pooled specification from Equation 1 on each subsample. I classify a district as *unwinnable* for the primary's party if the opposing party's presidential candidate won by at least 20 percentage points in the most recent presidential election. In such districts, the primary winner faces a near-certain general election loss, making it implausible that donors expect meaningful policy returns from their contribution.

The upper panel of Figure 5 presents the results. As a benchmark, I plot the baseline occupational affinity estimate (across all districts) of 6.6 percentage points at the top of the panel. Below this baseline, I plot separate estimates for winnable (6.4 percentage

Figure 5: Policy Investment: Occupation Donors Unresponsive to Office and Access



Note: The upper panel plots coefficients on same-occupation match from Equation 1, estimated separately on each subsample. *Unwinnable district*: the opposing party's presidential candidate won by ≥ 20 percentage points. All specifications include race-occupation fixed effects and incumbency controls. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. The lower panel plots the estimated effect of gaining a relevant committee assignment on log contributions, rescaled as $\exp(\hat{\beta}) - 1$ for interpretation as a percentage change. The PAC sample replicates Fouirnaies and Hall (2018) across 8 sector-committee pairings ($N = 354{,}792$). The individual sample covers 10 occupation-committee pairings across the same 8 committees ($N = 397{,}312$); health and education each map to two occupations. Both specifications include candidate-industry/occupation and candidate-year fixed effects, with robust standard errors clustered by candidate. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Supplemental Tables SA-7 and SA-8 report the underlying regression coefficients.

points) and unwinnable districts (7.4 percentage points). Although the estimate for unwinnable districts is imprecise, occupational affinity is, if anything, *larger* in races where the eventual nominee has no realistic prospect of holding office. This pattern is inconsistent with a purely instrumental account in which donors direct contributions toward candidates who can deliver policy benefits. Instead, it suggests that co-occupation donors support candidates from their profession regardless of whether that support is likely to translate into legislative influence.

Committee Access To evaluate the second prediction, I adapt the difference-in-differences design from Fouirnaies and Hall (2018), who show that interest group PACs increase contributions to legislators who gain seats on committees with jurisdiction over the group's

policy domain. I examine whether individual occupation donors exhibit a similar response, increasing support for any legislator who joins a profession-relevant committee irrespective of that legislator's own occupation. I implement this test among state legislators, where I can draw on the committee assignment data compiled by Fouirnaies and Hall (2018).

The lower panel of Figure 5 presents both estimates. I first replicate the PAC result across the 8 sector-committee pairings that correspond to occupations in my sample.[9] Consistent with Fouirnaies and Hall (2018), PAC giving increases by approximately 35 percent following a relevant committee assignment (N = 354,792). I then estimate the analogous specification for individual donors from each occupation across 10 occupation-committee pairings (N = 397,312). The result is effectively null: giving from occupation donors increases by approximately 2 percent, an estimate that is both small and statistically indistinct from zero. The contrast is striking: PACs, which are widely understood to behave strategically, respond strongly to committee assignments, while individual occupation donors do not. This divergence suggests that the mechanisms governing individual occupation giving differ fundamentally from the access-seeking logic that drives PAC contributions.

Taken together, these tests provide little support for narrowly instrumental accounts: co-occupation giving neither attenuates where the candidate is unlikely to win nor rises with committee access. Whatever drives individual co-occupation giving, it does not closely track the conditions under which strategic contributions would be most valuable.

Network Mobilization: Evidence from Law School Alumni

Having found little evidence for policy investment, I next ask whether professional *networks* play a more direct role in channeling co-occupation contributions. If shared professional ties activate occupational affinity, giving should be concentrated along specific network links, not diffused evenly across co-occupation donors. I therefore test whether attorney candidates raise disproportionately from donors who attended the same law

[9] Fouirnaies and Hall (2018) report results for 10 sector-committee pairings. I restrict to the 8 that map onto my individual donor analysis.

school. A same-school premium is not necessarily evidence of a network, however, since it could reflect geographic proximity or a shared credential alone. I address both alternatives below.

The attorney case offers a uniquely informative setting. Law schools create well-documented networks of alumni who share formative professional experiences and maintain ties through alumni associations, bar organizations, and referral networks. If these connections channel political contributions, a candidate should raise more from her own school's alumni than from comparable alumni of other schools. Restricting the analysis to attorneys and their attorney donors also holds occupation constant, isolating *within*-occupation network ties from the baseline occupational affinity documented above.

I estimate a within-candidate panel specification at the candidate-cycle × donor-school level. The panel includes all 246 law schools attended by at least one candidate in the sample, zero-filled for school-candidate dyads in which no donor from that school contributed. Each specification includes candidate-cycle fixed effects, so the coefficient on school match is identified from within-candidate variation: holding fixed everything about a candidate's fundraising environment, do donors from the candidate's own law school give more than donors from other schools? I estimate the model with two outcomes: the share of a candidate's total attorney fundraising from donors at a given school, and the log dollar amount from those donors.

A natural concern is that same-school giving reflects geographic proximity rather than institutional ties. A candidate and donor who attended the same state law school may simply live near each other, and proximity could drive the elevated giving rather than shared professional connections. To address this, the most demanding specification replaces school fixed effects with state × school fixed effects, absorbing state-specific school giving patterns and ensuring that the estimate is not driven solely by geographic overlap between candidates and their fellow alumni.

Table 5 presents the results. In the baseline specification, a same-school match (Candidate-Donor School Match) is associated with a 22 percentage point increase in the share of contributions from donors affiliated with a given law school (column 1) and

Table 5: Fundraising Advantage from Same-Law-School Donors

	Within-Candidate Share			Log(1 + Amount)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cand-Donor	0.22	0.15	0.06	3.77	4.57	2.62
School Match	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.05)	(0.11)	(0.10)
School Match ×		0.09	0.05		−1.01	−1.50
State Leg		(0.01)	(0.01)		(0.13)	(0.11)
Observations	1,220,652	1,220,652	1,220,652	1,220,652	1,220,652	1,220,652
Candidate-Cycles	4,962	4,962	4,962	4,962	4,962	4,962
Cand-Cycle FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
School FE	✓	✓		✓	✓	
State-School FE			✓			✓

The unit of observation is a candidate-cycle × donor-school. The panel covers primary-stage attorney candidates and the 246 law schools attended by at least one candidate. Cells in which no donor from that school gave are zero-filled. Candidate-Donor School Match is binary (0/1). Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's attorney fundraising from donor-school j. Columns (2) and (5) interact the match indicator with office type (House is the reference category); columns (3) and (6) replace school fixed effects with state × school fixed effects. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle.

a 3.77 log-point increase in dollars raised from those donors (column 4). These estimates suggest that, at least among attorneys, same-school alumni account for a substantial share of co-occupation contributions.

Columns 2 and 5 interact school match with an indicator for state legislative candidates (U.S. House as the reference). The same-school premium is larger for state legislative candidates in share terms (0.24 vs. 0.15) but smaller in log dollars (3.56 vs. 4.57). Despite this variation across offices, the premium is large and precisely estimated in both settings, confirming that alumni networks structure attorney fundraising across levels of office.

The most demanding specification (columns 3 and 6) replaces school fixed effects with state × school fixed effects, which absorb state-specific school contribution patterns. The same-school premium attenuates but remains substantial: 5.9 percentage points in share terms and 2.62 log points in dollars for House candidates, and 10.5 percentage points in share terms and 1.11 log points for state legislative candidates. The persistence of a sizable premium under these demanding controls, particularly for House candidates, is

consistent with alumni networks that operate nationally, channeling contributions through professional ties rather than geographic proximity alone.

Even after absorbing geography, a same-school premium could reflect a shared credential rather than a personal connection. Donors might read a common school as a signal of a candidate's competence or type and give on that basis, whether or not they were ever acquainted. These two accounts imply different patterns in *when* donor and candidate attended law school. An immediate professional network should concentrate giving among alumni whose enrollments plausibly overlapped, since these are the pairs likely to have known one another; a credential signal should not, because a shared school conveys the same information regardless of cohort. I test this by grouping a candidate's own-school donors by cohort distance ($|g|$), the absolute difference in years since bar admission between donor and candidate. I treat $|g| \leq 2$ as plausible co-enrollment, given a three-year law degree.[10]

Figure 6 re-estimates the same-school premium separately by cohort distance. The specification is the share model from Table 5, with the candidate's own-school cell split into equal-width bins of cohort distance. Each point is the premium for own-school donors in one bin, measured against the same different-school baseline.[11] The premium is concentrated among plausibly co-enrolled alumni and falls off sharply beyond them: 0.070 in the 0–2 bin against 0.023 in the 3–5 bin, a drop of 4.7 percentage points ($t \approx 16$). It declines toward zero across the remaining bins. Because a shared-credential signal implies a flat gradient, the observed concentration is more consistent with contributions flowing through an immediate professional network.[12]

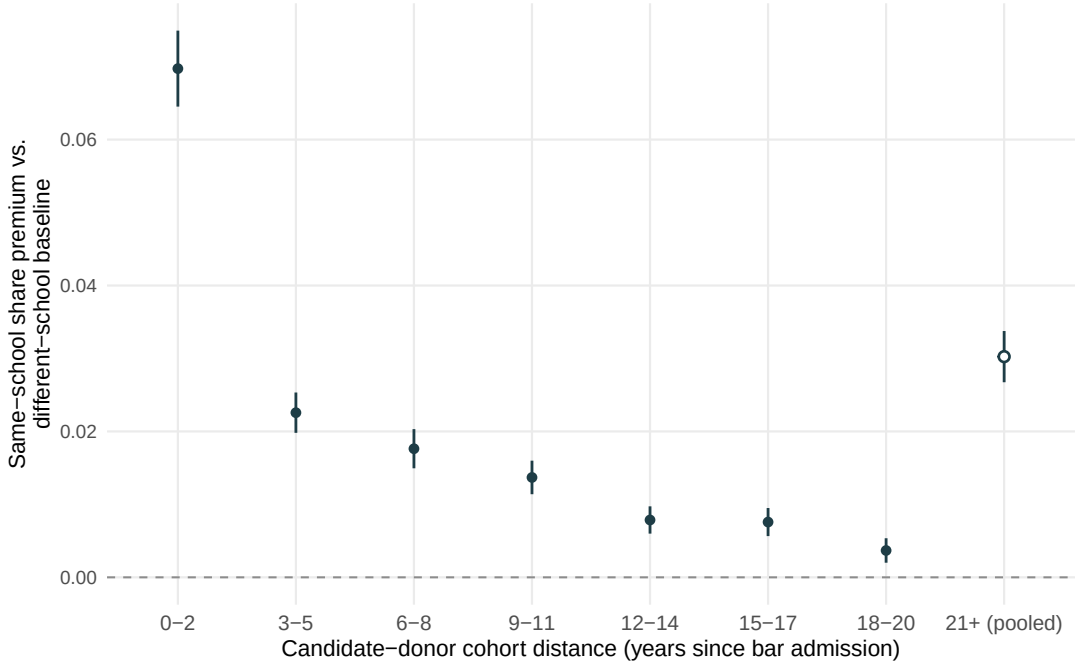
Of the mechanisms examined, the network channel finds the strongest support. Attorney candidates raise substantially more from same-law-school donors, beyond baseline occupational affinity. Two features mark this as a network rather than incidental overlap:

[10]Bar admission closely tracks graduation cohort. Years since bar admission is recorded in the Martindale–Hubbell directory for nearly all attorneys in the sample.

[11]Only equal-width bins are comparable, since a wider distance band mechanically accumulates more same-school dollars.

[12]The concentration is not an artifact of alumni supply. Plausibly co-enrolled alumni make up 11 percent of a candidate's available same-school alumni, slightly less than the 13 percent in the 3–5 bin, yet supply 38 percent of her same-school dollars, roughly three times their share of the pool. Across the equal-width bins, each bin's share of the available alumni pool changes gradually with cohort distance.

Figure 6: Same-School Giving Concentrates Among Plausibly Co-Enrolled Cohorts



Note: Plots coefficients on equal-width cohort distance bin indicators. These replace Candidate–Donor School Match in the column 1 specification of Table 5. *Cohort distance* ($|g|$): the absolute difference in years since bar admission between donor and candidate. Coefficients are measured against the different-school baseline. The specification includes candidate-cycle and school fixed effects. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. The hollow "21+" point pools a wider range of cohorts and falls outside the equal-width comparison. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Supplemental Table SA-9 reports the full regression coefficients.

it survives absorbing state-specific school giving (so geography alone does not produce it), and it concentrates among plausibly co-enrolled alumni, a pattern a personal connection predicts and a shared credential does not.

Discussion

This paper establishes occupational affinity as a consistent, substantively important feature of American legislative elections. Across a wide range of professions, offices, and contexts, candidates raise disproportionately from co-occupation donors. In primary elections, within-race comparisons put the advantage at roughly 7 percentage points of individual contributions, comparable to documented race- and gender-based affinities.

The professions that benefit most are not those whose members give most readily to their own. Co-occupation donors mobilize across nearly every field; what differs is the pool they can draw on. Only a narrow set of elite professions (attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives) draw on a sufficiently strong donor pool to convert that mobilization into a net advantage. Elsewhere, the same enthusiasm meets a thinner, less affluent base. The binding constraint is a profession's fundraising capacity, not its members' willingness to support their own. Still, even where affinity yields no net advantage, it can bind candidates to the professional base they depend on (Bawn et al. 2012, 2023).

The mechanism tests point away from narrowly instrumental explanations and toward professional networks and expressive identity. Co-occupation affinity does not weaken in districts a candidate's party cannot win, and individual donors, unlike PACs, do not respond when a legislator gains a profession-relevant committee seat, both difficult to reconcile with a policy-investment account. The strongest positive evidence is for networks: among attorneys, giving concentrates within law-school alumni ties even after absorbing geographic overlap.

These findings carry broader implications for representation. Because voters do not appear to penalize working-class candidates (Carnes and Lupu 2016), the professional makeup of a legislature is shaped largely upstream of the ballot: by who runs and who can assemble the resources to compete. Occupational networks act at exactly this stage:

by supplying money early, they filter the candidate pool, helping determine who appears viable before voters weigh in. That filter is most consequential at the point of entry, where occupational affinity is, if anything, strongest. Open-seat primaries most directly set a chamber's composition, and a candidate who prevails in one carries the advantages of incumbency forward across a career (Fouirnaies and Hall 2014; Jacobson 2015). In this way, the uneven distribution of professional fundraising capacity may tilt entry toward elite professions. Explaining the broader occupational imbalance, however, is a step beyond what this evidence can establish: working-class underrepresentation is pervasive across democracies and resists reduction to any single institution, campaign finance included (Carnes and Lupu 2026).

However it arises, that imbalance carries stakes well beyond the composition of the chamber. A legislator's occupational background shapes what she does in office, from the issues she prioritizes to her success in advancing them (Carnes 2012; Miler 2017; Francis and Bramlett 2017; Makse 2022). The professions best positioned to fund their candidates therefore help set the policy agenda once those candidates win, in domains as consequential as health insurance, the minimum wage, and taxation (Carnes 2013).

Several limitations merit discussion. First, because of the $200 federal itemization threshold and comparable thresholds at the state level, the analysis primarily observes donors who give above these amounts. Small-dollar fundraising has grown rapidly through platforms such as ActBlue, and occupational affinity may operate differently among unitemized small donors (Yorgason 2025). Second, the data capture only monetary contributions, and professional networks may also supply volunteers, expertise, endorsements, and introductions that matter for viability but go unobserved in campaign finance records. Third, the primary-election estimates remain conditional on candidate entry. Candidates from well-networked professions may selectively enter races where they expect a strong co-occupation donor base, while potential candidates who do not anticipate such support may select out of running altogether. The observed fundraising advantage therefore captures the role of occupational alignment among candidates who enter, rather than its broader effect on both entry and performance. This is a narrower estimand, but a

consequential one: it captures the advantage that helps determine who emerges as viable among those already competing. Fourth, the within-race design recovers a candidate's advantage relative to competitors in the same race, not whether co-occupation giving expands the pool of professional money or merely redistributes it across candidates—a distinction with sharper distributional stakes that this design cannot settle.

More broadly, these findings reframe a familiar question about representation. If early money matters for who can compete, and if access to it is distributed unevenly across professions, then the composition of American legislatures reflects not only the preferences of voters but also the structure of candidates' professional environments. Two extensions would sharpen the account: separating a profession's income from its organizational capacity—unionization, in particular, is among the few factors that predict working-class officeholding across democracies (Carnes and Lupu 2023)—and exploiting within-country variation in the cost of campaigns to test whether this fundraising channel matters most where money matters most. Understanding how professional networks form, mobilize, and channel campaign capital is therefore part of any complete account of who governs, and whose interests are most effectively represented.

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Supplemental Appendix

Contents

SA-1 Data and Occupational Classification SA-2
SA-1.1 Data Sources SA-2
SA-1.2 Occupational Schema SA-2
SA-1.2.1 Candidate Occupation Pipeline SA-2
SA-1.2.2 Donor Occupation Pipeline SA-3
SA-2 Occupation Classification Coverage SA-5
SA-3 Baseline Occupational Affinity, Excluding Zero-Dollar Observations SA-7
SA-4 Full Specification with Control Coefficients SA-8
SA-5 Regression Coefficients Behind the Main-Text Figures SA-11
SA-6 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections: Robustness to Alternative Outcome Treatment SA-15
SA-7 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections: Robustness to Alternative Fixed Effects SA-16
SA-8 Measurement-Error Correction: Design-Based Supervised Learning SA-17
SA-9 Representativeness of the Pooled Estimate SA-19
SA-10 Occupational Over-Representation in the Donor Pool SA-23
SA-11 Pooled Occupational Affinity, by Office SA-24
SA-12 Gender-Based Affinity SA-25
SA-13 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections, By Occupation and Chamber . . SA-26
SA-14 Contextual Variation: Alternate Outcomes SA-29
SA-15 Characterizing the Advantage: Out-Party Contributions SA-30
SA-16 Characterizing the Advantage: Alternate Outcomes SA-31
SA-17 Occupational Affinity and Net Fundraising: By Specific Occupation SA-32
SA-18 Occupational Affinity and Net Fundraising: State Legislatures SA-34

SA-1 Data and Occupational Classification

This appendix expands on the data sources and classification procedures summarized in the main text. It provides additional detail on the candidate occupation sources, the construction of the donor classification pipeline, and the disclosure rules that define the sample.

SA-1.1 Data Sources

The primary source for candidate occupations is Project Vote Smart (PVS), which offers the most comprehensive coverage of congressional and state legislative candidates. I supplement PVS with four additional datasets that vary in coverage: Ballotpedia candidate profiles; Makse (2019), covering state legislators from 1993 to 2012; Porter, Case, and Treul (2025), covering congressional candidates from 2018 to 2022; and the Martindale-Hubbell Law Directory as merged with DIME by Bonica and Sen (2017). These differences in coverage motivate the hierarchical integration described below.

On the donor side, I rely on individual contribution records sourced from DIME (Bonica 2024), which compiles contributions reported to the FEC and state agencies. These data include more than 34 million unique individuals between 1980 and 2024. The donor-reported occupation and employer fields accompanying itemized records form the basis for matching donors to occupational categories.

SA-1.2 Occupational Schema

Candidates and donors are classified into a common set of fourteen categories (Table 1), described in the main text. I additionally constructed classifications for three further occupations (dentists, pharmacists, and software developers) and one further industry (the pharmaceutical industry), but fewer than 100 candidates were assigned to any of these categories, producing highly unstable estimates; I therefore exclude them from the analysis. Because candidate and donor records differ substantially in structure and scale, I classify each through a distinct pipeline, described below.

SA-1.2.1 Candidate Occupation Pipeline

The baseline classification comes from Project Vote Smart. A large language model (Anthropic's Claude Haiku 4.5) reads each candidate's structured PVS career history and returns binary flags for the fourteen categories. This source initializes all flags and covers the plurality of candidates. I then layer the supplementary sources on top of this baseline using merge rules that are deliberately asymmetric. Each supplementary source records a job rather than a career: Ballotpedia's profession field typically names only a candidate's most recent position; Martindale-Hubbell is a bar directory, so it only observes attorneys; Makse (2019) assigns each legislator a single occupational category. In all of them, a recorded zero means "not listed," rather than "not true." Measurement error is therefore one-sided, as false negatives are common and false positives are relatively rare. The rules below let positives accumulate across sources while never allowing one source's silence to erase another's positive.

The first rule is *positive override*: a flag set to one by a supplementary source forces the combined flag to one, but a zero from that source never suppresses an existing positive.

Ballotpedia and Martindale-Hubbell (law directory) enter this way, as do two supplementary indicators drawn from candidates' PVS records: an attorney flag, based on law-related professional titles together with law-degree (JD) attainment, and a physician flag, based on medical-degree (MD) attainment. The second rule is *NA-fill*: a source supplies a value only where the baseline and higher-priority sources are missing, never overriding an existing classification. Ballotpedia also NA-fills, since it reaches candidates PVS misses entirely, as do Porter, Case, and Treul (2025)'s CampaignView (House candidates) and a residual layer of hand-coded attorney classifications. Makse enters as a positive-only NA-fill: because it assigns one category per legislator, it can move an unclassified candidate to one but is never read as a zero. Makse is further restricted to the four categories (attorney, corporate executive, insurance, and agriculture) that correspond one-to-one with a category in my scheme. The remainder either fall outside the fourteen or are broader than any single one of them: Makse's "Educator" spans my teacher and professor categories, "Public safety professions" spans law enforcement and firefighting, and "Skilled trades" extends well beyond construction. Consistent with this, the baseline classification confirms the four retained categories at rates of 77 to 97 percent, against 50 to 63 percent for the mapped categories I discard. The resulting precedence is: PVS-Haiku baseline; positive overrides and NA-fills from Ballotpedia; NA-fills from CampaignView; positive overrides from Martindale-Hubbell and the PVS record fields; positive-only NA-fills from Makse; and hand-coded attorneys.

To validate the combined candidate occupation classification procedure, I hand-coded two random samples of candidates against the fourteen categories: 200 that the procedure assigned to at least one category, and 150 it assigned to none. Of the 250 candidate-category labels the procedure assigned from candidates' biographical text, hand-coding confirmed 234 (precision = 93.6%). And of the 247 candidate-category labels identified by hand, the procedure recovered 234 (recall = 94.7%).

SA-1.2.2 Donor Occupation Pipeline

Donor occupation assignments rely on a hybrid procedure combining automated record linkage, LLM verification, and regular-expression matching. The primary method uses a deep-learning record-linkage model implemented through LinkTransformer (Arora and Dell 2023), applying the pre-trained `all-MiniLM-L6-v2` sentence-transformer model. Unique occupation strings are matched to the Bureau of Labor Statistics' Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) system, and employer strings are matched to the Center for Research in Security Prices (CRSP) database of publicly listed firms (1962–2024). For each string the model returns a best-matching entry and a cosine similarity score; I retain matches above 0.75 for occupations and 0.90 for employers.

For occupation matches in the intermediate similarity range (0.75–0.85), I verify classifications with an LLM (Anthropic's Claude Haiku 4.5), which reads each raw occupation string and assigns category flags directly, overriding the embedding classification where the two disagree. I further supplement the automated methods with regular-expression matching applied to all occupation strings, capturing common or unambiguous labels that may fall below the embedding threshold. A donor is flagged for an occupation if either the combined embedding/LLM pipeline or the regex identifies a match. On a hand-coded, stratified validation sample, the combined pipeline produces mean match rates of 88% for occupations and 91% for employers. Of the 11 million individual donors active in the sample period, roughly 9 million (84%) are classified into at least one occupational category and 2.7 million (25%) into one of the fourteen focal categories.

I hand-coded two random samples of donors against the fourteen categories: 200 assigned to ≥ 1 category and 150 assigned to a non-listed occupation. Of the 219 donor-category assignments the procedure made, 197 were confirmed (precision = 90.0%; 91.9% weighting by contribution dollars). Recall was 97.2%, and the marginal-band Haiku-verification step was correct on 30 of 33 labels it backed (90.9%).

SA-2 Occupation Classification Coverage

Table SA-1: Occupational Data Coverage Across Candidate Attributes, FEC-Consistent Disclosure Jurisdictions

Grouping	Count with Occupation	Total Count	Percent with Occupation
All Candidate-Cycles	31,817	43,168	73.7%
Primary Winner			
Lost	4,378	9,341	46.9%
Won	27,254	33,593	81.1%
General Winner			
Lost	9,198	18,128	50.7%
Won	20,015	21,930	91.3%
Chamber			
State: Lower	17,766	26,190	67.8%
State: Upper	5,668	7,729	73.3%
Federal: House	8,388	9,254	90.6%
Incumbent Status			
Open Seat	7,215	12,276	58.8%
Challenger	7,920	12,094	65.5%
Incumbent	16,296	17,819	91.5%

Note: The final column reports the share of candidate-cycles with non-missing occupation data (count with occupation divided by total count) within each group. Percentages are calculated within groups, not across them, and so need not sum to 100. Each attribute (primary winner, general winner, chamber, incumbency status) is a separate cross-tabulation of the same candidate-cycles, so group totals within an attribute draw on the full sample except for candidate-cycles with missing values on that attribute.

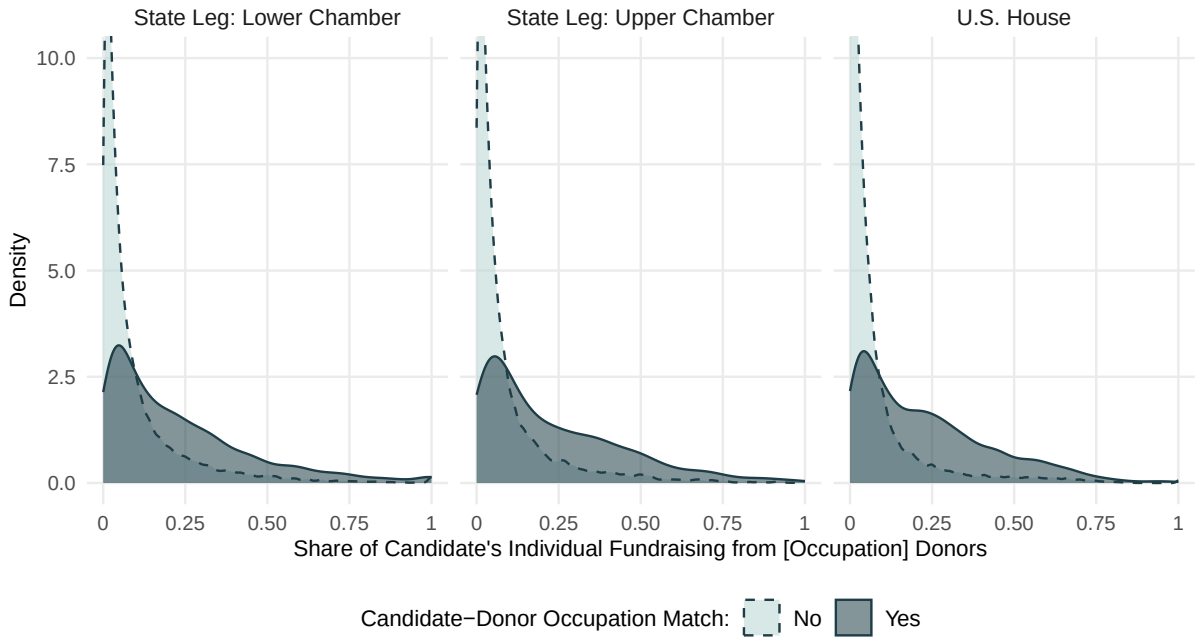
Table SA-2: Sample Construction: From Primary Election Data to Estimation Sample

Step	**Candidate-Cycles**
All candidate-cycles in primary election data	79,330
FEC-consistent disclosure jurisdictions	43,168
Sample restrictions	17,926
Non-missing occupation data (estimation sample)	**11,746**

Note: Candidate-cycle counts at each stage of sample construction. "Sample restrictions" refer to restricting the sample to regularly scheduled, contested, two-party primaries. State legislative races are further limited to single-member districts and exclude nontraditional primary formats (e.g., top-two and blanket primaries). The estimation sample (final row) comprises the candidate-cycles entering the within-race specifications in Equation 1, and equals the number of clusters reported in the regression tables.

SA-3 Baseline Occupational Affinity, Excluding Zero-Dollar Observations

Figure SA-1: Candidates Raise a Greater Share of Contributions from Their Own Occupation (Filtered to Observations with Positive Fundraising)



Note: Candidate-Donor Occupation Match indicates whether a candidate shares a background in occupation j with a set of donors. The outcome is the amount of money a candidate raised from occupation j, divided by the total amount they received from individual donors.

SA-4 Full Specification with Control Coefficients

This section reproduces the paper's principal regression tables with their full coefficients, including the incumbency controls omitted from the main text for space. Table SA-3 reproduces the within-race pooled specification of Table 2 with the incumbency-status coefficients shown. Table SA-4 does the same for the five dimensions of the fundraising advantage reported in Table 4. Table SA-5 does the same for the contextual estimates in Table 3; the incumbency indicators are omitted from the open-seat column, where they are constant by construction.

Table SA-3: Same-Occupation Fundraising Advantage: Full Coefficients

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Candidate-Donor	0.13	0.07	0.07	2.48	1.24	1.04
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.04)	(0.09)	(0.09)
Challenger			−0.02			−1.87
			(0.01)			(0.49)
Incumbent			0.03			1.90
			(0.01)			(0.48)
Open Seat			−0.01			−0.70
			(0.01)			(0.46)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746	11,746
Mean(y_{it})	0.07	0.07	0.07	5.23	5.23	5.23
Race-OCC FE		✓	✓		✓	✓

Full-coefficient companion to Table 2: identical specifications and sample, but the incumbency-status controls (suppressed in the main text) are printed. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. Log(1+OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount raised from occupation j donors.

Table SA-4: Dimensions of the Occupational Fundraising Advantage: Full Coefficients

	Early $ (1)	Donors (2)	Log(Avg. Gift) (3)	Out-State $ (4)	Out-Party $ (5)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.06	0.12	0.05	0.10
Occupation Match	(0.01)	(0.00)	(0.03)	(0.00)	(0.01)
Challenger	−0.02	−0.01	−0.33	−0.01	0.00
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.17)	(0.01)	(0.04)
Incumbent	0.04	0.02	0.26	0.03	0.02
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.17)	(0.01)	(0.04)
Open Seat	−0.01	−0.01	−0.16	−0.01	0.01
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.17)	(0.01)	(0.04)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	153,065	155,271	101,822	124,910	87,626
Candidate-Cycles	11,576	11,746	11,303	9,418	6,633
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Full-coefficient companion to Table 4: identical specifications and samples, but the incumbency-status controls (suppressed in the main text) are printed. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Columns (1), (2), (4), (5) are within-candidate shares (occupation-j $ or donors divided by the candidate's total in the corresponding pool); column (3) *Log(Avg. Gift)* is the natural log of the average contribution from occupation-j donors. Sample sizes in columns (3)–(5) are smaller because these outcomes require a nonzero denominator or at least one occupation-specific contribution.

Table SA-5: Fundraising Advantages from Same-Occupation Donors, Across Contexts: Full Coefficients

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.08	0.05	0.07
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Challenger	−0.02		−0.01	−0.03
	(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)
Incumbent	0.03		0.03	0.02
	(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)
Open Seat	−0.01		−0.01	−0.02
	(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)
Sample	Pooled	Open Seat	Safe	Crowded
Observations	155,271	57,340	61,121	68,098
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	4,441	4,583	5,152
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Full-coefficient companion to Table 3: identical specifications and sample, but the incumbency-status controls (suppressed in the main text) are printed. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. In the open-seat column (2) incumbency status is constant by construction, so the indicators are not estimable and are omitted. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors.

SA-5 Regression Coefficients Behind the Main-Text Figures

Several main-text results are presented as figures rather than tables. This section reports the full regression estimates behind them. Because the figures show transformed quantities (back-transformed dollar average marginal effects, or rescaled percentage changes), the coefficients below are not numerically equal to the plotted values. They are the estimates from the same fitted models.

Table SA-6 reports the Poisson coefficients behind Figure 4 (the elite/other decomposition), on the log scale. The figure shows the corresponding back-transformed dollar average marginal effects. Tables SA-7 and SA-8 report the estimates behind Figure 5: the district-safety subsample specifications (upper panel) and the committee-assignment difference-in-differences (lower panel). Table SA-9 reports the cohort-distance coefficients behind Figure 6.

Table SA-6: Elite/Other Dollar Decomposition: Full Coefficients

	U.S. House		State Legislatures	
	Total $	Co-occ $	Total $	Co-occ $
Candidate–Donor Occupation Match				
Elite occupations	0.34	0.70	0.11	0.55
	(0.09)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.15)
Other occupations	−0.24	0.29	0.01	0.66
	(0.09)	(0.11)	(0.16)	(0.29)
Challenger	0.13	0.18	−0.67	−0.97
	(0.58)	(0.58)	(0.46)	(0.54)
Incumbent	2.04	2.63	−0.20	−0.16
	(0.62)	(0.64)	(0.44)	(0.52)
Open Seat	−0.02	0.04	−0.36	−0.55
	(0.62)	(0.62)	(0.42)	(0.51)
Observations	67,421	60,414	87,850	57,921
Candidate-Cycles	5,047	5,008	6,700	6,528
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Backing full-coefficient table for Figure 4 (and, for the State Legislatures columns, Figure SA-5): the elite/other dollar decomposition of Equation 3, estimated by Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood, with the incumbency control coefficients shown. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Elite Occupation and Other Occupation are the coefficients on the candidate-donor occupation match interacted with the occupation group. Elite occupations are attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives, and other occupations are the remaining professions. Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. The dependent variables are total individual contributions (Total $) and same-occupation contributions (Co-occ $), in dollars. The figure plots the average marginal effects in dollars implied by these coefficients.

Table SA-7: Same-Occupation Premium by District Winnability: Full Coefficients

	Baseline	Winnable	Unwinnable
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.06	0.07
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.02)
Challenger	−0.02	−0.02	−0.11
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)
Incumbent	0.03	0.03	−0.11
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.03)
Open Seat	−0.01	−0.01	−0.13
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Observations	155,271	121,912	13,744
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	9,188	1,043
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓

Backing full-coefficient table for Figure 5 (upper panel): the baseline, winnable-district, and unwinnable-district estimates of Equation 1, with the incumbency control coefficients shown. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. The dependent variable is the within-candidate share of individual fundraising from same-occupation donors. A district is unwinnable for a candidate's party when the opposing party's presidential candidate carried it by at least 20 points in the most recent election.

Table SA-8: Committee Access and Contributions (Difference-in-Differences): Full Coefficients

	PAC $ (log)	Individual co-occ $ (log)
Gained Relevant Committee	0.300	0.023
	(0.016)	(0.016)
Candidate × Group FE	✓	✓
Candidate × Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	354,792	397,312
Candidates	16,182	13,564

Backing full-coefficient table for Figure 5 (lower panel): the effect of gaining a profession-relevant committee assignment on log contributions, estimated separately for PAC contributions (Fouirnaies & Hall 2018) and individual co-occupation contributions. Both specifications absorb all controls with candidate×group and candidate×year fixed effects, so the difference-in-differences coefficient is the only estimated parameter. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate. The dependent variable is log contributions from the relevant industry (PAC) or occupation (individual).

Table SA-9: Same-School Premium by Candidate–Donor Cohort Distance: Full Coefficients

	Same-School Share Premium
Cohort distance $\|g\|$ (years since bar admission)	
0–2	0.070
	(0.003)
3–5	0.023
	(0.001)
6–8	0.018
	(0.001)
9–11	0.014
	(0.001)
12–14	0.008
	(0.001)
15–17	0.008
	(0.001)
18–20	0.004
	(0.001)
21+	0.030
	(0.002)
Candidate-Cycle FE	✓
School FE	✓
Observations	1,255,386
Candidate-Cycles	4,962

Backing full-coefficient table for Figure 6: the equal-width cohort-distance gradient plotted in that figure. Each coefficient is the same-school share premium for candidate–donor pairs whose cohort distance $|g|$ (absolute difference in years since bar admission) falls in the indicated bin, relative to the different-school baseline. The specification is within-candidate with candidate-cycle and law-school fixed effects and no other controls, so there are no non-fixed-effect (e.g. incumbency) coefficients to report. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. The "21+" bin pools a wider range of far cohorts. The dependent variable is the share of a candidate's attorney fundraising from a given donor-school.

SA-6 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections: Robustness to Alternative Outcome Treatment

In this section I assess whether the log-dollar results survive alternative treatments of the outcome, considering the substantial number of candidate-occupation pairs that receive $0 in contributions. Because zeros are common, the $\log(1+\text{Amount}_{ijt})$ coefficients depend on the units of the outcome and lack a clean proportional interpretation (Chen and Roth 2024; Cohn, Liu, and Wardlaw 2022). The zeros also blend two distinct margins (whether occupation j gives to a candidate at all and how much it gives conditional on giving) that a single transformed outcome cannot separate. I therefore re-estimate the preferred specification under outcomes that avoid the transformation and decompose these two margins.

Table SA-10 re-estimates the preferred specification from Table 2 under four outcomes that vary only the dependent variable and estimator. Column (1) reproduces the main-text benchmark, $\log(1 + \text{OCC Funds})$. Column (2) replaces the transformation with Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood (PPML), which models the expected level of occupation-j funds directly rather than a transformation of it (Silva and Tenreyro 2006). PPML handles zeros without an added constant, is invariant to the outcome's units, and yields coefficients that read as proportional differences in expected dollars. Because it drops fixed-effect groups whose outcome is zero for every candidate, its estimation sample is smaller. Columns (3) and (4) separate the margins: (3) is a linear probability model for receiving any occupation-j money, and (4) is the log amount among candidates who receive a positive amount.

Table SA-10: Same-Occupation Fundraising Advantage: Robustness to Outcome Treatment

	Log(1+OCC Funds) (1)	OCC Funds (2)	Pr(OCC Funds>0) (3)	Log(OCC Funds) (4)
Cand-Donor	1.04	0.64	0.07	0.59
Occ. Match	(0.09)	(0.11)	(0.01)	(0.06)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Funds > 0
Observations	155,271	118,335	155,271	101,806
Cand-Cycles	11,746	11,535	11,746	11,303
Estimator	OLS	PPML	OLS	OLS
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

All columns hold the preferred specification fixed: race-occupation fixed effects, an incumbency control, and the binary Candidate-Donor Occupation Match indicator. Robust standard errors are clustered by candidate-cycle. Only the dependent variable and estimator vary. (1) OLS on $\log(1 + \text{OCC Funds})$; (2) PPML on OCC Funds in levels (smaller sample: PPML drops fixed-effect groups with no positive contributions); (3) linear probability model on $\mathbf{1}\{\text{OCC Funds} > 0\}$; (4) OLS on log(OCC Funds) among candidates with positive OCC Funds. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. OCC Funds is the amount a candidate raises from occupation-j donors.

SA-7 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections: Robustness to Alternative Fixed Effects

In this section, I present results on occupational affinity in primary elections using the pooled specification outlined in Equation 1. In these models, however, I incorporate alternative fixed-effects structures to demonstrate the robustness of the findings. Column 1 adds a candidate fixed effect to the baseline race-occupation fixed effect, while column 2 replaces the combined race fixed effect with separate district-party-occupation and cycle fixed effects, thereby leveraging more of the available variation in the data. Importantly, the specification in column 1 cannot be estimated using the within-candidate occupation fundraising share outcome, since that outcome is already defined by comparisons within candidate. Including a candidate fixed effect in that setting would generate highly correlated observations across candidate-cycle-occupation rows. To address this constraint, I instead use the logged amount raised from occupation j as the outcome variable.

Table SA-11: Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections: Robustness to Alternative Fixed Effects

	Within-Candidate Share		Log(1 + OCC Funds)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.06	1.04	0.95	0.85
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.09)	(0.05)	(0.07)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271	155,271
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	
Race-OCC FE	✓		✓		✓
Candidate FE					✓
District-Party-OCC FE		✓		✓	
Cycle FE		✓		✓	

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency (except Col 2, where it is absorbed by candidate FE). Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising from occupation j donors. Log(1 + OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors. Cols (1) and (3) reproduce the preferred specification from Table 2. Cols (2) and (4) replace race-occupation FE with separate district-party-occupation and cycle FE. Col (5) adds candidate fixed effects.

SA-8 Measurement-Error Correction: Design-Based Supervised Learning

The main-text analysis classifies candidate occupations with an imperfect pipeline. To assess whether this measurement error distorts the estimates, I apply the design-based supervised learning (DSL) correction described in the main text (Egami et al. 2023). Table SA-12 reports the naive and corrected estimates for the pooled, elite, and non-elite specifications. Table SA-13 reports the per-occupation classifier accuracy on the hand-coded calibration sample that anchors the correction.

The correction uses a probability sample of 570 hand-coded candidates with known sampling probabilities, and targets the candidate–donor occupation-match coefficient on the within-candidate fundraising share in Equation 1. Because the DSL estimator requires dense fixed-effect dummies, the models in Table SA-12 use seat×state×party×occupation fixed effects in place of the paper's race×occupation fixed effects. Under these coarser fixed effects the naive estimate is 0.062, against a race×occupation benchmark of 0.066, and adding cycle fixed effects leaves the corrected pooled estimate at 0.079.[1] The corrected estimates exceed the naive ones throughout (0.079 versus 0.062 pooled; 0.125 versus 0.089 among elite occupations), a pattern consistent with classifier error attenuating the coefficient on a binary regressor.

Table SA-12: Naive versus DSL-Corrected Estimates of Occupational Affinity

Specification	Naive (SE)	DSL-corrected (SE)
Pooled	0.062 (0.002)	0.079 (0.006)
Elite	0.089 (0.003)	0.125 (0.015)
Non-elite	0.039 (0.002)	0.044 (0.004)

Candidate–donor occupation-match coefficient on the within-candidate fundraising share (Equation 1), naive versus corrected with design-based supervised learning (Egami et al. 2023), on a probability sample of 570 hand-coded candidates. Fixed effects are seat×state×party×occupation (see text). Elite occupations are attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle in parentheses.

[1] Clustering instead at the candidate level, the sampling unit for the calibration draw, leaves the corrected estimates essentially unchanged; the pooled estimate remains 0.079, with a standard error of 0.007 rather than 0.006.

Table SA-13: Per-Occupation Classifier Accuracy on the Hand-Coded Calibration Sample

Occupation	Precision	Recall
Attorneys†	0.847	0.958
Physicians†	0.930	1.000
Corporate Execs†	0.878	0.907
Accountants	0.978	0.671
Agriculture	0.954	0.854
Construction	0.959	0.746
Fossil Fuel	0.881	0.752
Insurance	0.948	0.928
Investments	0.866	0.698
Law Enforcement	0.898	0.957
Nurses	0.976	1.000
Professors	0.806	0.982
Real Estate	0.957	0.978
Teachers	0.932	0.931

Inverse-probability-weighted precision and recall by occupation on the 570-candidate calibration sample. † denotes elite occupations. Recall for rare categories (e.g., accountant, investments, fossil fuel) is imprecise, since few false negatives are sampled.

SA-9 Representativeness of the Pooled Estimate

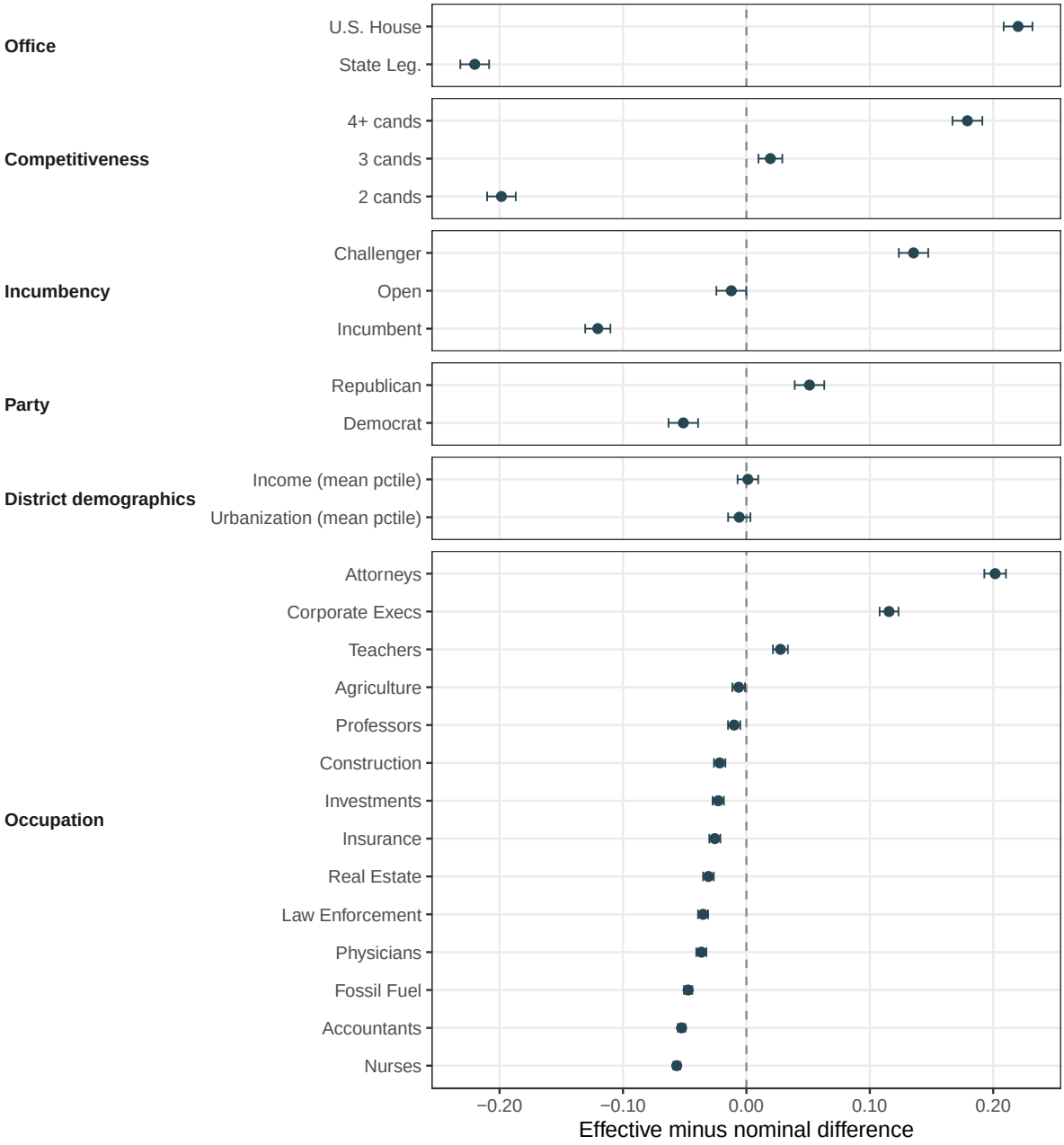
Because the fixed-effects estimator weights observations by the conditional variance of the occupation-match indicator, the pooled estimate is identified from an effective sample that need not match the nominal one (Aronow and Samii 2016). I recover that sample by regressing the match indicator on the race-occupation fixed effects and the incumbency control and weighting each observation by its squared residual. Candidates whose occupational profile is well predicted by the race they run in contribute little to identification; those who differ from their primary opponents contribute most. The resulting weights are highly concentrated. Half of the identifying weight comes from 13% of candidate-cycles, and 90% from just over a third of them. Figure SA-2 compares the weighted composition of the sample to its unweighted composition, characteristic by characteristic. Identification tilts toward competitive, crowded, non-incumbent U.S. House primaries and toward attorneys and corporate executives, the two largest occupational groups among donors. District income and urbanization differ from the nominal sample by statistically indistinguishable amounts.

This re-weighting matters for interpretation only if the co-occupation advantage differs across the races the estimator up-weights. Table SA-14 tests that directly, interacting the match indicator with terciles of three district characteristics: median household income, urbanization, and the share of local employment in occupation j. Income comes from the ACS five-year median household income table (B19013) and urbanization from the decennial census (urban share of housing units). Both are measured once per redistricting era, at a year whose district boundaries match that era's plan, and attached to every cycle in the era. Local occupational employment comes from the ACS one-year detailed occupation table (B24010), pooled across same-boundary releases within each era. Terciles are assigned within cycle, so each district is ranked against the others contesting the same election, and within cycle and occupation for local employment, since employment shares are not comparable across occupations. All three moderators are measured at the congressional-district level, so this table uses U.S. House candidates only. The sample narrows further across columns: urbanization is unavailable for the 2022 cycle, and B24010 isolates a clean occupational category for only seven of the fourteen occupations (attorneys, physicians, nurses, accountants, professors, teachers, and law enforcement).

The interactions are small and statistically insignificant throughout. On the within-candidate share, the low-tercile effect is roughly 0.07 in all three columns and no interaction exceeds 0.015 in absolute value, about a fifth of the main effect and well within sampling error of zero. The log-dollar outcome shows the same pattern. The co-occupation advantage therefore does not vary systematically with district affluence, urbanization, or the local supply of same-occupation professionals, which is what would have to be true for the composition differences in Figure SA-2 to change the estimand.

Table SA-15 takes the complementary approach and drops the observations carrying the most weight. Removing the candidate-cycles in the top 5, 10, 13, and 25 percent of the weight distribution leaves the coefficient intact, and if anything raises it, from 0.066 on the full sample to 0.091 with the top quarter of weight removed. Excluding attorneys and corporate executives, the groups the effective sample most over-weights, lowers the estimate to 0.049 but leaves it precisely estimated and far from zero. The pooled result is not an artifact of a handful of high-leverage races, nor of the two occupations that dominate the donor pool.

Figure SA-2: Composition of the Effective versus Nominal Sample



Note: Plots the difference between the effective and nominal samples in each characteristic, for the pooled within-race specification (Equation 1). Positive values indicate a characteristic overweighted in identification. For office, competitiveness, incumbency, party, and occupation the quantity is the sample *share*; for income and urbanization it is the district's mean *within-cycle percentile rank*, so all quantities lie on a common 0–1 scale. District-demographic comparisons are U.S. House only. Bars are 95% confidence intervals from a bootstrap that resamples candidate-cycles, with 1,000 replications.

Table SA-14: Homogeneity of the Occupation-Match Effect Across District Types

	Income	Urbanization	Occ. Employment
Within-Candidate Share			
Occupation Match (Low tercile)	0.071	0.070	0.069
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)
× Mid tercile	-0.013	-0.002	-0.002
	(0.010)	(0.011)	(0.011)
× High tercile	-0.002	-0.012	0.015
	(0.010)	(0.011)	(0.011)
Observations	67421	57647	33834
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓
Controls	✓	✓	✓
Log(1 + OCC $)			
Occupation Match (Low tercile)	1.010	1.234	1.191
	(0.166)	(0.150)	(0.260)
× Mid tercile	-0.055	-0.169	-0.095
	(0.226)	(0.247)	(0.340)
× High tercile	0.199	-0.320	0.008
	(0.225)	(0.225)	(0.332)
Observations	67421	57647	33834
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓
Controls	✓	✓	✓

Each column interacts the occupation-match indicator in Equation 1 with terciles of a district characteristic. The "Low tercile" row is the main effect; the mid- and high-tercile rows are interactions relative to it. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries, U.S. House only. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. Log(1+OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors.

Table SA-15: Sensitivity of the Pooled Estimate to High-Weight Races and Elite Occupations

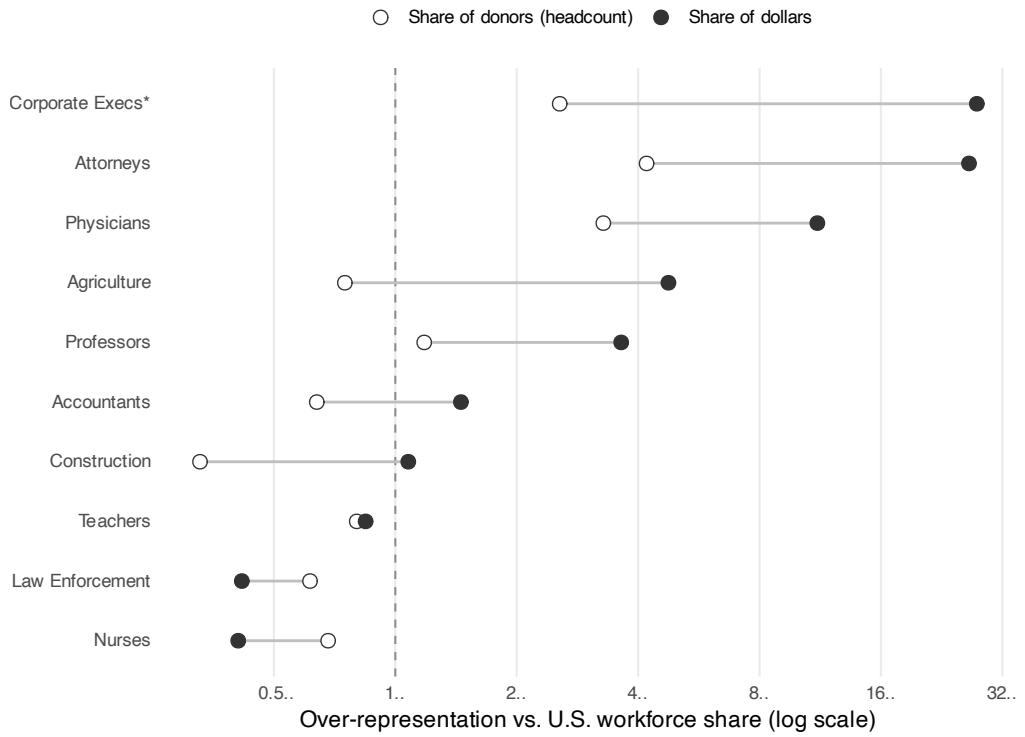
	Within-Candidate Share		Log(1 + OCC $)		
Sample	β	(SE)	β	(SE)	Obs.
Full sample	0.066	(0.004)	1.042	(0.086)	155,271
Drop top 5% weight	0.073	(0.005)	1.143	(0.099)	147,038
Drop top 10% weight	0.079	(0.006)	1.161	(0.122)	138,833
Drop top 13% weight	0.078	(0.007)	1.142	(0.138)	133,931
Drop top 25% weight	0.091	(0.012)	1.256	(0.230)	114,516
Drop attorney + exec	0.049	(0.004)	0.860	(0.127)	132,519

Each row re-estimates the pooled occupation-match coefficient (Equation 1) on the indicated subset. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). All specifications include race-occupation fixed effects and an incumbency control. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. Log(1+OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors.

SA-10 Occupational Over-Representation in the Donor Pool

A related question is whether the co-occupation results merely reflect some occupations flooding the donor pool. Figure SA-3 shows they do not: over-representation is confined to a few elite professions, while most occupations—including several for which the main analysis still detects co-occupation affinity—sit at or below parity relative to the workforce, so the affinity results cannot be an artifact of pool composition.

Figure SA-3: Occupational Over-Representation in the Individual Donor Pool



Note: Plots each occupation's share of the individual donor pool divided by its share of U.S. employment (American Community Survey, 2019 one-year estimates), on a $\log_2$ scale. The dashed line marks parity, values above it indicate over-representation relative to the workforce. *Open circles*: the occupation's share of classifiable individual donors in DIME active in 2004 or later, across all recipients. *Filled circles*: its share of the $12.3 billion in individual contributions to U.S. House and state-legislative candidates, 2004–2022 (not of all campaign giving); both series cover 2004 onward, when donor occupation reporting becomes reliable. The bar connecting the two points shows how much more (or less) over-represented an occupation is in dollars than in donor numbers. Because the two measures use different denominators (donors to any recipient versus dollars to these candidates), read each point against the parity line rather than as an exact multiple of the other. Occupational flags are not mutually exclusive, so shares cannot be summed across occupations. Corporate executive uses the broad ACS "Top executives" category, which also captures general and operations managers, so its ratios are conservative lower bounds. The figure covers the ten of the fourteen categories in Table 1 with a direct American Community Survey occupational match; real estate, fossil fuel, insurance, and investments have no comparable ACS occupational denominator.

SA-11 Pooled Occupational Affinity, by Office

Table SA-16: Fundraising Advantages from Same-Occupation Donors, by Office

	Within-Candidate Share		Log(1 + OCC Funds)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Candidate-Donor	0.07	0.07	1.06	0.94
Occupation Match	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.09)	(0.16)
Challenger	−0.01	−0.01	−0.63	−1.15
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(1.06)	(0.61)
Incumbent	0.04	0.02	4.52	0.60
	(0.02)	(0.01)	(1.07)	(0.59)
Open Seat	−0.01	−0.01	−0.45	−0.30
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(1.07)	(0.58)
Sample	U.S. House	State Leg.	U.S. House	State Leg.
Observations	67,421	87,850	67,421	87,850
Candidate-Cycles	5,047	6,700	5,047	6,700
Mean(y_{it})	0.07	0.06	6.63	4.16
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from occupation j donors. Log(1+OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors.

SA-12 Gender-Based Affinity

Table SA-17: Female Candidates' Fundraising Advantage from Female Donors

	Within-Candidate Share	Log(1 + Female Funds)
	(1)	(2)
Female Candidate	0.09	0.61
	(0.00)	(0.05)
Challenger	0.00	−0.39
	(0.01)	(0.16)
Incumbent	−0.07	0.94
	(0.01)	(0.16)
Open Seat	−0.01	−0.21
	(0.01)	(0.15)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	29,730	29,730
Race FE	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Female Candidate is binary (0/1). Incumbency-status coefficients (Challenger, Incumbent, Open Seat) are relative to the reference category of candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Within-Candidate Share is the share of a candidate's total individual fundraising that comes from female donors. Log(1 + Female Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from female donors.

SA-13 Occupational Affinity in Primary Elections, By Occupation and Chamber

Table SA-18: Occupational Fundraising Advantages: U.S. House vs. State Legislatures (Part 1 of 2)

	U.S. House	State Legislatures
Accountants	0.313 (0.250)	-0.368 (0.592)
Challenger	-0.136 (0.477)	-0.481 (0.720)
Incumbent	2.078*** (0.528)	-0.028 (0.708)
Open Seat	-0.261 (0.517)	-0.312 (0.703)
Attorneys	0.459*** (0.130)	0.825*** (0.147)
Challenger	0.084 (0.726)	-0.667 (0.450)
Incumbent	2.308** (0.750)	0.084 (0.410)
Open Seat	0.021 (0.770)	-0.376 (0.363)
Physicians	1.505*** (0.234)	2.143** (0.692)
Challenger	0.359 (0.780)	-0.689 (1.010)
Incumbent	2.428** (0.815)	0.324 (0.989)
Open Seat	0.339 (0.814)	-0.125 (0.993)
Nurses	1.381*** (0.364)	1.024 (0.590)
Challenger	1.588* (0.777)	-0.579 (0.701)
Incumbent	3.310*** (0.836)	-0.200 (0.632)
Open Seat	1.262 (0.845)	0.014 (0.600)
Professors	0.635** (0.200)	1.190* (0.561)
Challenger	0.954 (0.633)	-1.250 (1.117)
Incumbent	2.688*** (0.684)	-0.819 (0.954)
Open Seat	0.868 (0.715)	-0.601 (0.808)
Law Enforcement	1.134** (0.369)	1.085* (0.552)
Challenger	-0.365 (0.754)	0.100 (1.030)
Incumbent	1.762* (0.834)	-0.029 (0.855)
Open Seat	-0.667 (0.814)	-0.030 (0.759)
Teachers	-0.439 (0.226)	0.480 (0.300)
Challenger	1.063 (0.790)	-0.915 (0.663)
Incumbent	2.649** (0.827)	-0.551 (0.607)
Open Seat	0.867 (0.844)	-0.486 (0.559)
Observations	3,366–4,863	2,259–5,898
Race FE	✓	✓

Coefficients are drawn from 28 separate Poisson regressions (14 occupations × 2 levels of office), split across the two parts of this table. Specification outlined in Equation 2. Sample sizes vary across specifications because Poisson estimation omits fixed-effect groups in which contributions are zero for all candidates. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle in parentheses. The indented rows report the incumbency coefficients, relative to candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Agriculture, Construction, Fossil Fuel, Insurance, and Investments are industry aggregates, the remaining categories are individual occupations. Table 1 gives the full category definitions. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Table SA-19: Occupational Fundraising Advantages: U.S. House vs. State Legislatures (Part 2 of 2)

	U.S. House	State Legislatures
Real Estate	-0.115 (0.317)	0.524 (0.604)
Challenger	0.074 (0.485)	-1.252* (0.605)
Incumbent	2.438*** (0.580)	-0.554 (0.573)
Open Seat	-0.032 (0.554)	-0.959 (0.527)
Corporate Execs	0.788*** (0.150)	0.221 (0.259)
Challenger	0.017 (0.569)	-1.032 (0.657)
Incumbent	2.522*** (0.616)	-0.053 (0.644)
Open Seat	-0.070 (0.595)	-0.648 (0.629)
Fossil Fuel	0.847 (0.628)	-0.069 (0.678)
Challenger	0.437 (0.524)	-1.628 (0.981)
Incumbent	3.912*** (0.666)	-0.357 (0.935)
Open Seat	-0.402 (0.619)	-0.637 (0.896)
Insurance	0.435 (0.322)	0.305 (0.794)
Challenger	0.478 (0.542)	-0.453 (0.761)
Incumbent	2.983*** (0.617)	0.074 (0.767)
Open Seat	0.338 (0.614)	-0.509 (0.692)
Agriculture	0.545* (0.260)	1.086* (0.498)
Challenger	0.344 (0.657)	-1.747* (0.749)
Incumbent	2.986*** (0.740)	-0.785 (0.689)
Open Seat	-0.109 (0.686)	-0.547 (0.493)
Construction	-0.106 (0.243)	0.779 (0.796)
Challenger	-0.788* (0.325)	-0.861 (0.696)
Incumbent	1.743*** (0.435)	-0.214 (0.647)
Open Seat	-0.944* (0.372)	-0.654 (0.599)
Investments	0.343 (0.247)	0.039 (0.378)
Challenger	-0.269 (0.613)	-1.389 (0.915)
Incumbent	2.512*** (0.728)	-0.507 (0.887)
Open Seat	-0.511 (0.678)	-0.901 (0.859)
Observations	3,987–4,679	2,592–5,803
Race FE	✓	✓

Coefficients are drawn from 28 separate Poisson regressions (14 occupations × 2 levels of office), split across the two parts of this table. Specification outlined in Equation 2. Sample sizes vary across specifications because Poisson estimation omits fixed-effect groups in which contributions are zero for all candidates. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle in parentheses. The indented rows report the incumbency coefficients, relative to candidates with unrecorded incumbency status. Agriculture, Construction, Fossil Fuel, Insurance, and Investments are industry aggregates, the remaining categories are individual occupations. Table 1 gives the full category definitions. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

SA-14 Contextual Variation: Alternate Outcomes

Table SA-20: Fundraising Advantage from Same-Occupation Donors, Across Contexts (Log Outcomes)

	Log(1 + OCC Funds)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Candidate-Donor	1.04	1.09	0.85	1.11
Occupation Match	(0.09)	(0.17)	(0.13)	(0.09)
Sample	Pooled	Open Seat	Safe	Crowded
Observations	155,271	57,340	61,121	68,098
Candidate-Cycles	11,746	4,441	4,583	5,152
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Log(1 + OCC Funds) is the natural log of the amount of money a candidate raises from occupation j donors.

SA-15 Characterizing the Advantage: Out-Party Contributions

Table SA-21: Out-Party Occupational Affinity: Robustness to Alternate Outcomes and Partisanship Thresholds

	Within-Candidate Share		Log(1 + Out-Party $)	
	75%	80%	75%	80%
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Candidate-Donor	0.10	0.10	0.89	0.78
Occupation Match	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.08)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	87,626	76,412	155,271	155,271
Candidate-Cycles	6,633	5,781	11,746	11,746
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. Donors are classified as strong partisans if they gave to at least four distinct major-party candidates and directed at least 75% (cols. 1, 3) or 80% (cols. 2, 4) of their contributions to one party. Within-Candidate Share is occupation-j out-party $ divided by the candidate's total out-party $; Log(1 + Out-Party $) is the natural log of occupation-j out-party dollars. Column (1) is the main specification (Table 4, column 5). Share columns have smaller samples because they require a nonzero out-party denominator.

SA-16 Characterizing the Advantage: Alternate Outcomes

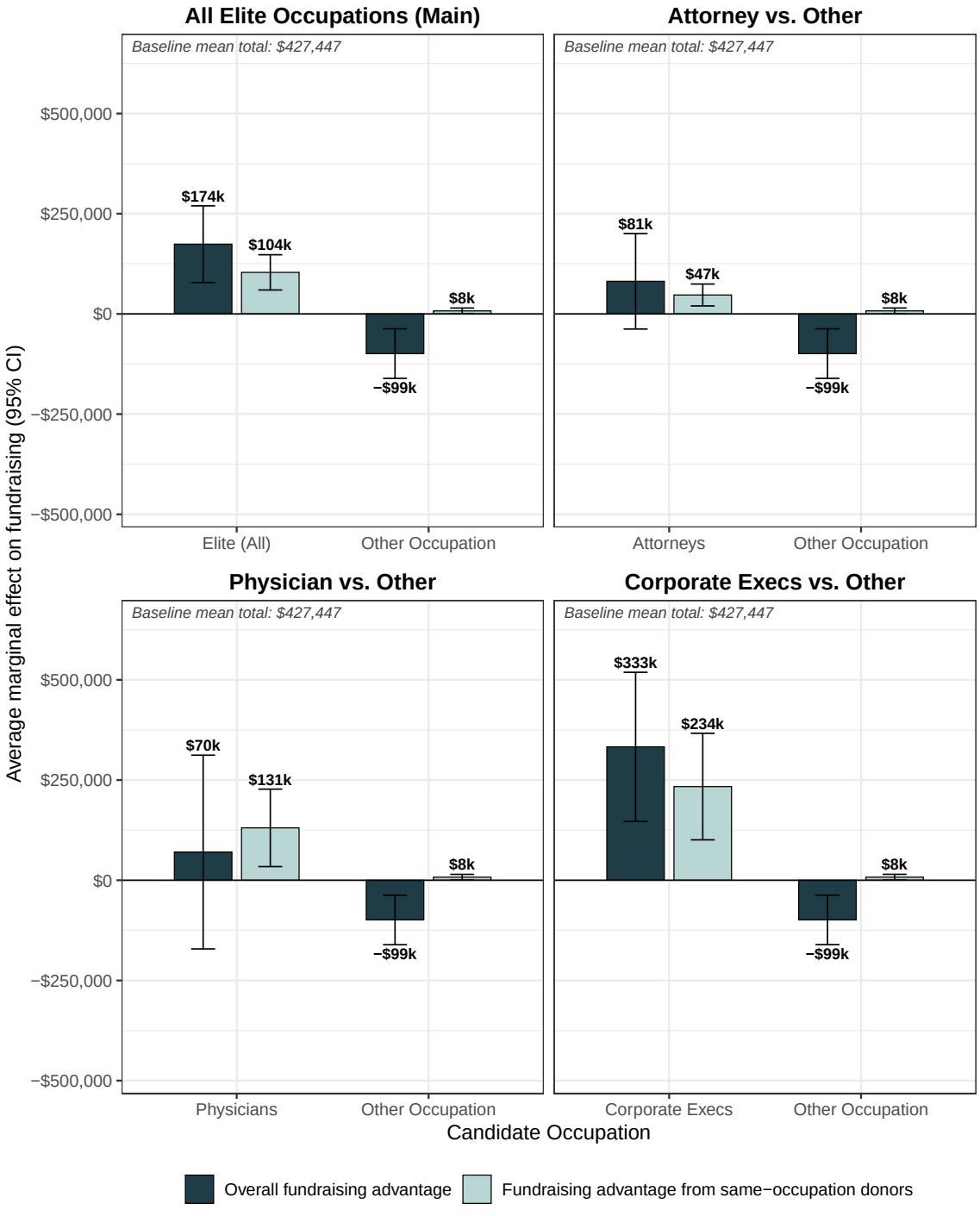
Table SA-22: Dimensions of the Occupational Fundraising Advantage (Log Outcomes)

	Early $ (1)	# Donors (2)	Avg. Gift (3)	Out-State $ (4)	Out-Party $ (5)
Candidate-Donor	1.12	0.49	0.12	0.86	0.78
Occupation Match	(0.09)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Sample	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled	Pooled
Observations	153,238	155,271	101,822	155,271	155,271
Candidate-Cycles	11,585	11,746	11,303	11,746	11,746
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Race-OCC FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidate-Donor Occupation Match is binary (0/1). Controls include incumbency. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries. All outcomes are logged: each is estimated by OLS using the $\log(1 + x)$ transformation. *Early $*: dollars from occupation-j donors in the first 90 days. *# Donors*: count of occupation-j donors. *Avg. Gift*: average contribution from occupation-j donors. *Out-Party $* and *Out-State $*: dollars from out-party and out-of-state occupation-j donors.

SA-17 Occupational Affinity and Net Fundraising: By Specific Occupation

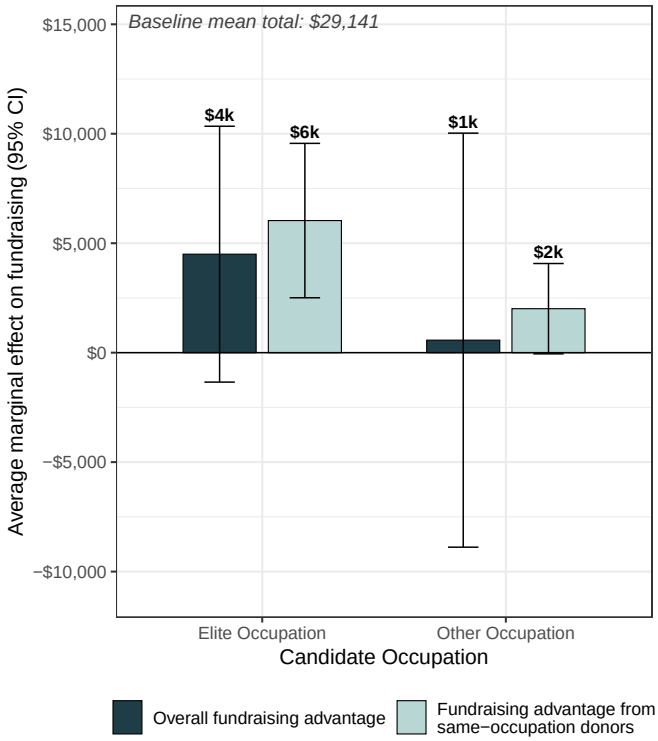
Figure SA-4: Fundraising Advantage of Elite Occupations in U.S. House Primaries (By Individual Occupation)



Note: Average marginal effects from Poisson regressions of individual contributions (2024 USD) on candidate-donor occupation match interacted with occupation group (elite vs. other), with incumbency controls and race-occupation fixed effects. Two outcomes per group: total individual contributions and same-occupation contributions. Elite occupations: attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives. Other occupations: remaining eleven occupations. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries.

SA-18 Occupational Affinity and Net Fundraising: State Legislatures

Figure SA-5: Fundraising Advantage of Elite Occupations in State Legislative Primaries



Note: Average marginal effects from Poisson regressions of individual contributions (2024 USD) on candidate-donor occupation match interacted with occupation group (elite vs. other), with incumbency controls and race-occupation fixed effects. Two outcomes per group: total individual contributions and same-occupation contributions. Elite occupations: attorneys, physicians, and corporate executives. Other occupations: remaining eleven occupations. Bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Robust standard errors clustered by candidate-cycle. Candidates restricted to Democrats and Republicans in contested primaries.